



GOAL AREA 2

Every child, including adolescents, learns and acquires skills for the future

Global Annual
Results Report 2024

unicef 
for every child

Image on Cover page: © UNICEF/UNI725007/Iyakaremye
Children learning how to build a toy car during play time at an
early childhood development center in Rubavu district, Rwanda.
December 2024.

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Children learn using tablets during an e-learning session at
Alshargia safe learning space in Kassala, Sudan. March 2024.



Expression of thanks

UNICEF's work for children is funded entirely through the voluntary support of millions of people around the world and our partners in government, civil society and the private sector. Voluntary contributions enable UNICEF to deliver on its mandate to protect children's rights, help meet their basic needs and expand their opportunities to reach their full potential.

UNICEF expresses its gratitude to all partners whose overall contributions supported education and adolescent development programmes in 2024. The achievements described in this report were the result of these committed and trusted partnerships.

A special acknowledgement is extended to partners who contributed thematic funding to UNICEF. Thematic contributions to education at the country, regional or global level allowed UNICEF the flexibility and agility to deliver technical, operational and programming support, including in humanitarian settings. UNICEF is particularly grateful to the governments of Luxembourg, Norway and Sweden, and to its private sector partners Ahlström Collective Impact (ACI), Chery Automobile, easyJet, ING España, Sandvik Coromant, Saxo and others who contributed to the global thematic fund in 2024, including through National Committees, in support of UNICEF's education work for the 2022–2025 Strategic Plan period.

Abbreviations and acronyms

AI	Artificial intelligence	OOSC	Out-of-school children
ECE	Early childhood education	P2E	Passport to Earning
ECW	Education Cannot Wait	SBC	Social and behaviour change
FLAT	Foundational Learning Action Tracker	SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
GCI	Gender at the Centre Initiative	STEM	Science, technology, engineering and mathematics
GEC	Global Education Cluster	TaRL	Teaching at the Right Level
GenU	Generation Unlimited	UNESCO	United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization
GPE	Global Partnership for Education	UNICEF	United Nations Children's Fund
INEE	Inter-agency Network for Education in Emergencies	WASH	Water, sanitation and hygiene
MHPSS	Mental health and psychosocial support		

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Executive summary

The year 2024 was one of both progress and challenges. Several interconnected factors have slowed meaningful advancement for learning and skilling of children and young people, ranging from broad global pressures such as political instability, economic disparity and the effects of adverse climate and weather-related events to more specific problems such as limited financial support and a lack of skilled personnel. UNICEF's commitment to advancing education reached 142 countries, driving significant progress in both development and humanitarian contexts. With an estimated expenditure of US\$1.6 billion – US\$922 million of which was allocated to humanitarian settings – UNICEF's efforts transformed education systems, expanded access to learning, and strengthened resilience in the face of crises.

The transformation of education systems was evident in technical support provided to strengthen national education sector plans. By 2024, nearly three quarters (73 per cent) of countries had implemented evidence-based plans addressing inequities and aligning with Sustainable Development Goals – a significant rise from 65 per cent in 2023.

As part of systems-strengthening, UNICEF worked on accountability tracking as a crucial tool in improving learning outcomes. UNICEF spearheaded initiatives such as the Safe to Learn assessment, monitoring progress in 16 countries to tackle violence in schools, and the Foundational Learning Action Tracker, which assessed efforts across 123 countries, including a pilot for early childhood education.

At the heart of the learning crisis is limited literacy and numeracy by the age of 10 years. UNICEF also scaled up remedial support for foundational learning in 17 countries, focusing on evidence-based strategies to accelerate literacy and numeracy. Also employed were strategies that foster learning, including addressing mental health. By the end of 2024, 80 UNICEF country offices were working with governments to develop or enhance mental health and psychosocial support (MHPSS) policies and programmes, ensuring that children's mental well-being became a core component of education systems.

In terms of expanding access to learning, one of the most striking achievements was the reach of UNICEF's education initiatives. In 2024, 26 million out-of-school children and adolescents gained access to education, including 9 million in humanitarian settings and 3.7 million children on the move.

Ensuring that marginalized children and youth – especially girls and learners with disabilities – were not left behind remained a priority. Through policy advocacy, incentive programmes and digital inclusion strategies, UNICEF drove efforts to expand equitable access to education. As a result, 56 per cent of countries reported having inclusive and gender-equitable learning systems, while 44 per cent had gender-responsive systems for learning and skills development – up from 36 per cent in 2023.

Recognizing the urgency of creating more resilient education systems, UNICEF supported risk-informed programming and capacity development, resulting in an increase in the number of countries with resilient education systems from 32 per cent in 2023 to 40 per cent in 2024. These strengthened systems ensured that children and communities could better cope with disruptions while maintaining access to education. Climate disruptions continued to pose a major challenge to education, with at least 242 million students facing climate- or weather-related school disruptions in 2024. Globally, UNICEF integrated climate education into learning opportunities in 90 countries, while also facilitating youth participation in climate initiatives across 137 countries.

To accelerate the achievement of results, UNICEF employed digital transformation strategies. By 2024, 26 per cent of countries had effective digital learning solutions in place, up from 22 per cent in 2023. Through its leadership in the Common Framework for Digital Transformation, UNICEF facilitated international cooperation, while study visits to Egypt and Indonesia fostered knowledge exchange among 20 countries. More than 18 million children accessed education through digital platforms, including nearly 10 million through the Learning Passport.

Youth engagement remained a cornerstone of UNICEF's efforts. In 2024, 22.7 million adolescents in 101 countries took action to address issues affecting their lives, with 20.9 million engaged in development settings and 1.8 million adolescents in humanitarian settings, demonstrating how UNICEF is increasingly relying on young people to respond to crisis. Systems-strengthening efforts continued, with 61 per cent of UNICEF country offices establishing platforms for meaningful youth engagement.

Context

As the world approaches the deadline of Agenda 2030, the Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) scorecard for Goal 4 on education¹ shows mixed results: some countries are progressing too slowly to achieve the SDG targets, while many others are making good progress. For example, while 25 per cent of countries see stagnation in early childhood education (ECE) attendance, 34 per cent are seeing fast progress towards their national targets.

Globally, the number of out-of-school children (OOSC) and young people has hovered around 265 million for a decade and the latest estimate shows that there were 272 million OOSC in 2023.² This number shows regional and economic disparities and inequalities, with 107 million out-of-school children living in the sub-Saharan African region and a 36 per cent out-of-school rate in low-income countries, compared to 3 per cent in high-income countries.

Worldwide, 234 million children in crisis contexts require support to access quality education – an estimated increase of 35 million over the past three years.³ In the State of Palestine, conflict disrupted learning for nearly 660,000 students in Gaza. In Sudan, more than 17 million of the 19 million school-aged children remained out of school. In Haiti, escalating gang violence and civil unrest left over 1.4 million children in urgent need of education support. Of the 234 million children requiring education support, 85 million are completely out of school. Among these 85 million, 52 per cent are girls, 17 per cent are refugees or internally displaced, and over 20 per cent are children with disabilities.

Increasing gaps across the learning and skills acquisition course, from early childhood through to adolescence and youth, need to be urgently addressed. Data indicate that at the age of school entry (5 years), close to three quarters of children are developmentally on track.⁴ However, at age 10, more than half of children cannot read and comprehend a simple text.⁵ And by the age of school completion (18 years), only one quarter of young people have the skills required for life and work.⁶ Young people face growing challenges in skilling and employment, with one in five aged 15–24 classified as not in education, employment or training (NEET) – a rate that is twice as high for young women compared to young men.⁷

Three systemic conditions are derailing learning. The first is when children do not have access to education in the first place. Second, schools and systems are failing children who attend but are not learning. Third, a multitude of factors such as conflict, climate change and poverty are forcing children to drop out of education. Systemic shortfalls highlight long-standing barriers and biases, as well as limited capacities to adapt to emerging challenges. For example, girls, especially in low-income regions, face greater barriers to education due to economic pressures, early marriage or caregiving responsibilities, exacerbated by crises and climate change-related adversities. Indigenous and minority groups often face compounded

challenges, including discrimination, lack of resources, and exclusion from policy planning, programme design and implementation processes. Learners with disabilities are 49 per cent more likely to be out of school compared to their peers and are disproportionately affected by disruptions in education caused by crises. Additionally, schools have increasingly become targets in conflict settings, undermining their role as safe spaces.

Significant progress in learning has been impeded by several factors that stem from a combination of external global dynamics such as economic inequality, political instability and climate change, and sector-specific challenges such as human resource shortages and inadequate financial investment. Globally, at least 242 million students have experienced school disruptions due to weather and climate-related events in 2024.⁸ Disasters such as floods, hurricanes and wildfires have increasingly disrupted education, destroyed schools and displaced communities, with their associated health impacts such as heatwaves and pollution impacting students' ability to attend school and concentrate in the classroom. War and instability also make education inaccessible for millions in the State of Palestine, Sudan, Syria, Ukraine, Yemen and elsewhere. Refugee crises have placed a significant strain on education systems in host countries, with insufficient resources to meet demand.

While education financing was already inadequate, economic strains have reduced government budgets for education in many countries, leading to cutbacks in resources, teacher salaries and infrastructure investments. Additionally, data show that the poorest benefit from only 16 per cent of public education funding, while the wealthiest benefit from about 28 per cent. This disparity becomes more pronounced in low-income countries, where 11 per cent of public education resources go to the poorest, while 42 per cent go to the richest.⁹

The rapid growth of technology and artificial intelligence (AI) is transforming the global education landscape, with the potential to improve both access to, and the quality of, learning. By 2030, more than 60 per cent of jobs will require advanced digital skills,¹⁰ yet over half of children in low-income countries are likely to remain offline,¹¹ exacerbating the digital divide. This gap in access to technology could further widen educational inequalities, as AI-powered learning tools become more common in wealthier regions. As AI continues to influence labour markets, millions of unskilled young people could be left at a significant disadvantage in future job markets, lacking the competencies needed to thrive.

Despite these challenges, UNICEF works with partners to mitigate the impact of diverse disruptors and deliver sustainable solutions that address barriers and core system failures to ensure that every child and young person in school and learning.



Anjali, a student in Chhattisgarh, India, showcases her sewer-cleaning robot at her school's AtalTinkering Lab (ATL) where STEM subjects are promoting a culture of innovation and entrepreneurship. December 2024.

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Results in Goal Area 2 in 2024

Overview of results and funding



SDG 4: Quality education

Ensure that all girls and boys complete **free, equitable and quality primary and secondary education** (Target 4.1)

Substantially increase the number of youth and adult who have **relevant skills for employment** decent jobs and entrepreneurship (Target 4.4)

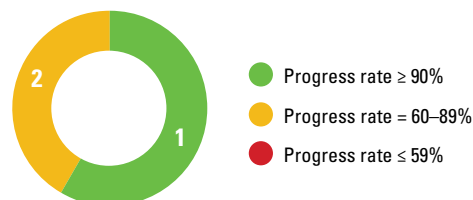
Ensure that all youth achieve **literacy and numeracy** (Target 4.6)

Education is a right enshrined in articles 28 and 29 of the Convention on the Rights of the Child. UNICEF's Core Commitments for Children (CCCs) in education also underscore the urgency of ensuring learning continuity, particularly in crisis settings. UNICEF's work in Goal Area 2 of the Strategic Plan, 2022–2025, including in humanitarian crises and fragile settings, advances the achievement of SDG 4. UNICEF also contributes to many other SDGs, including SDG 5 on gender equality and the empowerment of women and girls, and SDG 8 on sustainable, inclusive economic growth and decent work for all.

Despite the compounding challenges hindering global progress towards SDG 4, significant efforts have been made to help children and young people access quality learning, including by leveraging technology and scaling proven solutions. In 2024, UNICEF achieved significant progress across both Goal Area 2 Results Areas. Results Area 1 focuses on equitable and inclusive access to

learning opportunities, including in humanitarian and fragile contexts, and results show a 114 per cent per cent achievement against milestones. Result Area 2 focuses on improved learning, skills, participation and engagement for all children and adolescents, with an 81 per cent per cent achievement in 2024.

FIGURE 1. Progress against 2024 milestones by Results Area



14-year-old Basila is photographed in her Grade 5 classroom in Batash School in Faizabad city, Badakhshan province, Afghanistan. She hopes to become a teacher one day. November 2024.



Goal Area 2: Learning and skills acquisition



26 million children and adolescents accessed education, including nearly 9 million in emergencies



17.5 million children reached with learning materials, including nearly 5 million in emergencies

In 2024, UNICEF received US\$819 million in new funds for Goal Area 2. Public sector partners contributed 80 per cent of overall funding (US\$654 million), while private sector partners contributed 20 per cent (US\$165 million). UNICEF worked on Goal Area 2 in 142 countries in 2024, with total expenses of US\$1.6 billion, including US\$922 allocated to humanitarian settings.

FIGURE 2. Strategic Plan Outcome indicator 2.3

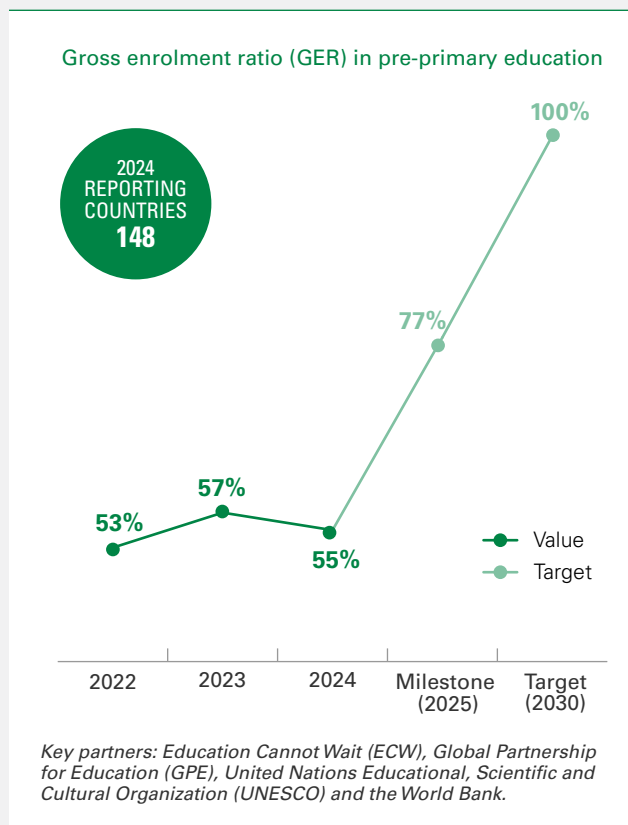
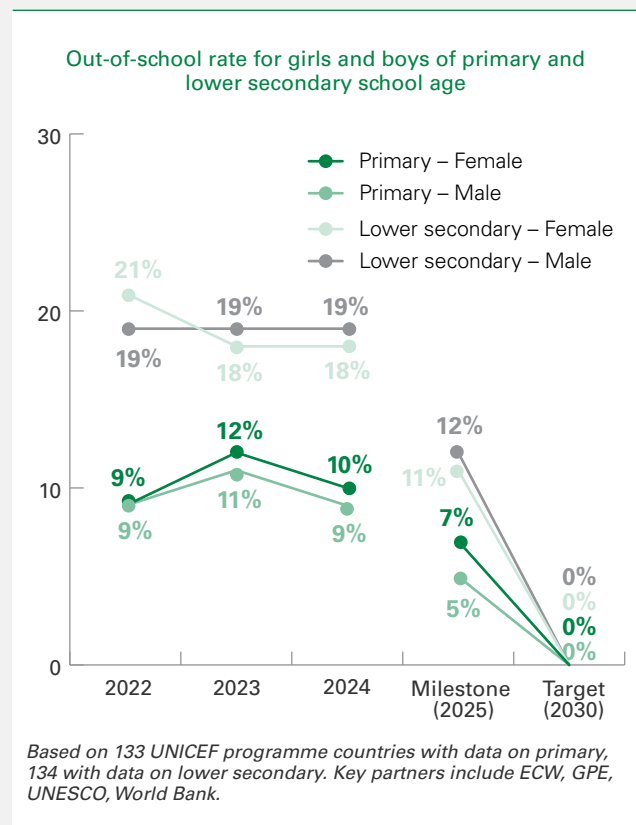


FIGURE 3. Strategic Plan Outcome Indicator 2.4



Supplying education for every child

In 2024, UNICEF procured US\$86.7 million worth of child-friendly, age-appropriate, culturally and gender-sensitive education supplies for 108 countries. This includes UNICEF’s iconic education kits, delivering 60,577 school-in-a-box kits, 19,871 early childhood development kits and 27,068 recreation kits. More than 11,000 tents were provided to 58 countries, some of which were used as temporary classrooms. UNICEF also delivered assistive and inclusive supplies to reach more than 261,000 children with disabilities.



A School-in-a-Box delivered as part of the back-to-school emergency response following Tropical Storm Kristine (Trami) in the Philippines. October 2024.

Results achieved in Goal Area 2 Results Area 1: Equitable and inclusive access to learning opportunities, including in humanitarian and fragile contexts

Despite recent progress, there are a significant number of children who are not attending school. For those who are attending school, too many are not learning the skills they need to succeed. UNICEF’s work in 2024 addressed both challenges: increasing access to education and improving the quality of education.

Outcome-level data show that the gross enrolment ratio in pre-primary education has been stagnating. With a rate of 55 per cent in 2024, accelerated efforts are required to reach the 2025 Strategic Plan target of 77 per cent. Out-of-school rates have remained high for five straight years, also requiring enhanced effort to reach the 2025 Strategic Plan milestone and SDG target of 0 per cent by 2030.

TABLE 1. Gross enrolment ratio in pre-primary education, 2022–2024

Outcome level indicator 2.3:		2022	2023	2024	Milestone (2025)	Target (2030)
Gross enrolment ratio in pre-primary education	148 UNICEF programme countries with data	53%	57%	55%	77%	100%

Key partners: ECW, GPE, UNESCO and the World Bank.

TABLE 2. Out-of-school rate for girls and boys of primary and lower secondary school age, 2022–2024

Outcome level indicator 2.4:		2022	2023	2024	Milestone (2025)	Target (2030)
Out-of-school rate for girls and boys of primary and lower secondary school age	Primary – Female	9%	12%	10%	7%	0%
	Primary – Male	9%	11%	9%	5%	0%
	Lower secondary – Female	21%	18%	18%	11%	0%
	Lower secondary – Male	19%	19%	19%	12%	0%

Based on 133 UNICEF programme countries with data on primary education and 134 with data on lower secondary education. Key partners include ECW, GPE, UNESCO and the World Bank.

At the output level, a proportion of countries supported by UNICEF have not yet established inclusive and gender-equitable education (Result 2.1.1) or education systems that are resilient to crises (Result 2.1.2). Nevertheless,

by maintaining the current momentum, it is possible to achieve the 2025 Strategic Plan targets of 65 per cent and 49 per cent, respectively.

TABLE 3. Progress against Strategic Plan Results Area 1 output-level indicators

Results/ Output-level indicators		2021 Baseline	2024 Value	2025 Target	
2.1.1	Inclusive and gender-equitable system (percentage of countries)	46	56	65	On track
2.1.2	Education system resilient to crises (percentage of countries)	30	40	49	On track
2.1.3	Evidence-based education sector plans/ strategies (percentage of countries)	48	73	63	Achieved
2.1.4	Number of out-of-school children and adolescents who accessed education (millions)	49	150	114	Achieved

Access to education in the early years

Every child deserves the best start in life. Through strategic advocacy and action to increase access to early learning opportunities, UNICEF enabled 2.9 million out-of-school children to enrol in pre-primary education in 2024, up from 2.4 million in 2023. More than 40 per cent of this enrolment has been achieved in Eastern and Southern Africa, a region where half of children do not have access to the minimum one year of pre-primary education, followed closely by the East Asia and Pacific region. For example, through technical discussions and public consultations in **China**, UNICEF

supported the drafting of the Preschool Education Law enacted in 2024 to accelerate the universalization of pre-primary education.

UNICEF continues to lead global efforts to expand equitable access to quality early childhood education (ECE), placing inclusion, gender responsiveness and resilience at the heart of its strategy. Recognizing that the early years lay the foundations for lifelong learning, UNICEF has tackled the structural barriers that prevent millions of young children – especially those affected by poverty, conflict, disability or gender bias – from accessing the support they need to thrive.



Students participate in a group activity at an early childhood education center in Areesha camp in Al-Hassakeh governorate, Syria. August 2024.

Championing inclusive and gender-responsive early learning, at the 62nd United Nations Commission for Social Development, UNICEF elevated the importance of addressing gender socialization from the earliest years, presenting evidence-based advocacy on the need to tackle gender inequality from the early years.¹² In parallel, UNICEF has prioritized disability inclusion in ECE by adapting sector analysis tools and launching a three-year scaling research initiative, supported under the GPE–International Development Research Centre Knowledge and Innovation Exchange grant. This work is equipping countries to better design and deliver ECE systems that meet the diverse needs of all learners.

UNICEF also broke new ground by advancing early learning in humanitarian settings. Recognizing the devastating impact of crises on early childhood development, UNICEF convened key actors across the humanitarian ecosystem to contribute to the development of global guidance on ECE in emergencies. Aligned with the Humanitarian Programme Cycle, this guidance positions quality, inclusive early learning as a critical component of crisis preparedness, response and recovery. The collaborative process strengthened partnerships with ECW, the Global Education Cluster (GEC), the Inter-Agency Network for Education in Emergencies (INEE), the Moving Minds Alliance Donor Consortium and GPE – bringing diverse voices and financial resources to early learning in emergencies.

In **South Sudan**, UNICEF supported the development of an ECE Learning Activity Guide and teacher training manuals designed for conflict settings, embedding gender and inclusion in every aspect of curriculum design. In **Sierra Leone**, a comprehensive, community-informed review of the national ECE framework integrated both gender-responsive and environmentally conscious approaches, producing an actionable road map for systems-strengthening. In **Tajikistan**, UNICEF’s gender-inclusive and disability-sensitive guidance informed the use of the ECE Costing and Financing Tool to simulate investments and develop financing strategies that promote equitable ECE access at scale.

Innovation has also driven new models of service delivery to expand access. In **Kenya**, UNICEF has been supporting the training of young entrepreneurs, who, in turn, started an ECE centre, providing quality early learning to young children and enhancing school readiness while also creating jobs for other young people as teachers and support staff. Drawing on this and other successful examples from **Bangladesh, Jordan and South Africa**, UNICEF is exploring ways for governments to steward social entrepreneurship in ECE, empowering young entrepreneurs to establish community-based services that expand access, especially in underserved areas.¹³

Reaching out-of-school children and adolescents with learning opportunities

Since 2022, UNICEF programmes have reached 150.5 million out-of-school children (OOSC), surpassing the 2024 cumulative target of 97.3 million by 54 per cent. In 2024 alone, 26 million children benefited from UNICEF programmes across 97 countries, including 9 million children in humanitarian settings and 3.7 million children on the move. UNICEF supported governments to deliver evidence-based strategies such as community-based approaches that are breaking down barriers for marginalized children. In 2024, 97 reporting countries reintegrated OOSC into the education system. For example, **Bangladesh** enrolled 300,000 Rohingya children, and **Guatemala's** initiatives for 150,000 indigenous learners doubled their anticipated reach through adaptive, community-driven models.

In the conflict-affected **Democratic Republic of the Congo**, UNICEF accompanied the government to build 374 new classrooms and supported community mobilization and teacher training. **Liberia's** Back to My Classroom campaign helped reintegrate 37,000 children, boosting enrolment from 46 per cent to 51 per cent, particularly for adolescent girls. In the **Maldives**, through the leveraging of community schools and trained specialists, two new inclusive education units served 1,000 children with disabilities across remote islands. **Guinea's** alternative education programmes in 200 community learning centres reintegrated 15,000 rural children back into school, raising primary enrolment to 84.2 per cent. In **Myanmar**, where nearly a third of school-age children remain out of school due to protracted crises, UNICEF reached over 1 million children, half of them girls, with learning opportunities, teaching aids and learning materials, resulting in the continuation of their education amid the conflict.

By using schools as integrated service delivery platforms, UNICEF's education programmes worked closely with health, nutrition, child protection, mental health and psychosocial (MHPSS), water, sanitation and hygiene (WASH), social policy and protection, disability inclusion and gender programmes to provide comprehensive support for children in crisis. In **Sudan**, 1,500 safe learning spaces, known as 'makannas', were established to provide children with access to an integrated package of services, including education, protection and WASH. These spaces delivered structured learning programmes and psychosocial support to 690,000 children (51 per cent girls), helping them cope with the emotional and psychological impacts of conflict. In the **State of Palestine**, 143,784 children (48 per cent girls) were supported in accessing formal or non-formal education, including through the establishment of safe learning spaces benefiting 85,741 children (46 per cent girls) in Gaza. Through these integrated, cross-sectoral efforts, UNICEF ensured that education in emergencies goes beyond learning to provide children with the essential health, protection and social support they need to thrive despite devastating conditions.

These results indicate a shift in addressing the global OOSC crisis, which was latest estimated at 272 million children in 2023.¹⁴ UNICEF's strategies focused on community engagement and improving infrastructure to reach marginalized children, including girls and those with disabilities. In addition, innovative evidence-based practices such as alternative learning pathways, tailored curricula and strengthened education systems created scalable models for humanitarian and underserved settings.

Strengthening inclusive and gender-equitable education systems

Gender-responsive access to learning opportunities

In 2024, UNICEF made strides towards inclusive and gender-equitable education systems, though more work is needed. In 133 countries, 56 per cent achieved gender-responsive access to learning opportunities in 2024, a slight decline from 57 per cent in 2023. This drop reflects uneven progress, with gains in some areas offset by setbacks in regions affected by conflict and displacement. UNICEF continued to support governments to integrate gender-responsive policies into education systems, to reach millions of girls through scalable programmes.

In **Nepal**, the Supporting Adolescent Girls' Education Programme enrolled 2,918 adolescents (92 per cent girls) in non-formal learning, with 80 per cent expected to re-enter formal education in 2025. **Argentina's** New School for Adolescents (PLaNEA) programme reached 35,500 students by focusing on marginalized girls through gender-inclusive strategies and intersectoral advocacy. In **Malaysia**, the Future Skills for All Initiative empowered 43,838 children (57 per cent girls) with digital skills by embedding inclusivity with accessibility features to bridge gender and technological divides.

In **Kenya**, the Digital Literacy Programme supported 50,000 girls in arid regions, hardest hit with gender disparities, equipping them with science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM)-focused digital tools and supported by gender-responsive teacher training. In **Bangladesh**, 15,000 young mothers resumed education through flexible re-entry policies and schedules and stigma-reducing campaigns, ensuring continued access to education post-pregnancy. **Ghana's** Girls' Education Clubs reached 25,000 girls in 500 schools, providing menstrual hygiene facilities to reduce absenteeism and empowering girls to advocate for their learning.

In **Senegal**, over 113,700 girls in 4,548 schools benefited from the UNICEF-supported National Strategy for Girls' Retention, with initiatives such as separate toilets and washable menstrual pads produced by female vocational graduates. This tackled menstruation-related barriers, boosting attendance for 10,000 empowered girls. In **Mali**, UNICEF enhanced WASH services in 20 secondary schools,

training more than 500 participants (53 per cent girls) to make sanitary pads locally, improving attendance and confidence amid crises. **Mauritania's** UNICEF-supported National Education Sector Development Programme 2023–2030 introduced gender-sensitive management, raising preschool enrolment from 9.2 per cent to 15.2 per cent. In **Malawi**, the BEFIT programme reached 3.6 million learners across 6,420 primary schools, focusing on girls through gender-sensitive literacy interventions and remedial education. Training was provided to 2,600 teachers, and 3 million teaching and learning materials were distributed, enhancing girls' retention and reducing dropout rates from 4.8 per cent to 4.2 per cent.

Disability-inclusive education

In 2024, UNICEF supported 102 countries to advance disability-inclusive education systems, with 58 per cent reporting an enabling environment for inclusive education systems – up from 55 per cent in 2023 and 47 per cent in 2022. Through its programmes in development and emergency contexts, UNICEF reached nearly 513,000 children with disabilities worldwide. This included 272,875 out-of-school children and adolescents, 8,464 children accessing education through digital learning platforms, and individual learning materials provided to 389,037 children. While much progress is still needed, these results reflect improved mainstreaming of children with disabilities across education programmes and demonstrate the success of UNICEF's continued advocacy with governments for inclusive education.

To address the persistent lack of quality data on children with disabilities and their educational experiences, UNICEF and the Washington Group on Disability Statistics launched two new data collection tools: the Inclusive Education Module, which captures data on barriers to access and participation, and the Child Functioning Module–Teacher Version, designed for integration into national education data systems to enable inclusive education management information systems. These tools are key to enabling governments to plan, monitor and strengthen inclusive education systems.

Thought leadership and knowledge-sharing remained a critical pillar of UNICEF's efforts to drive the disability-inclusive education agenda in 2024. As co-chair of the Global Action on Disability Network's Inclusive Education Working Group, UNICEF maintained strong coordination, advocacy and knowledge exchange with stakeholders, including donors, multilaterals, civil society, and organizations of persons with disabilities. Several global public goods were published that documented promising practices in inclusive education, including in emergencies, and internal capacity on reaching children with disabilities and including them in education was strengthened through dedicated technical assistance, webinars and knowledge exchange across countries and regions.

UNICEF's support to governments in systems-strengthening led to progress across many countries. In **Lebanon**, following the approval of the National Policy on Inclusive Education for Children with Special Needs, UNICEF supported the Ministry of Education to develop a costed three-year road map and an inclusive education handbook. The partnership also enabled the roll-out of inclusive education school programmes in 117 public schools, reaching nearly 7,000 children with disabilities, representing 14 per cent of children with disabilities in the education system. Among children in flexible learning pathways, 4 per cent are children with disabilities who received assistive devices, classroom support and therapy. In **Senegal**, UNICEF partnered with civil society and national authorities to train 100 school personnel, and it launched a national initiative with ATScale, the World Health Organization and the Ministry of Health to integrate school-based screening and assistive technologies. Additionally, 22,038 children benefited from disability-inclusive, gender-sensitive digital cash transfers linked to education



Grade 3 student Kaye received a Learning Kit as part of a back-to-school emergency response at her school in Camarines Sur, the Philippines. December 2024.

outcomes. In **Nigeria**, learning materials were provided to over 1 million children, including 167,716 children with disabilities. In **Iran**, more than 7,500 Braille textbooks supported learning for children with visual impairments.

Children with disabilities are disproportionately impacted during humanitarian emergencies, often facing multiple, compounded barriers to accessing essential services, including education, thus exacerbating their exclusion.

In the **State of Palestine**, UNICEF adapted learning spaces and provided mobility aids in Gaza. In **Iraq**, UNICEF supported the integration of inclusive education principles in school rehabilitation and modernized disability information systems, and in **Afghanistan**, community-based education classes specifically reached children with disabilities in conflict-affected areas.

CASE STUDY: Advancing inclusive education: getting the most vulnerable children back to school in Egypt



Egypt faces significant education challenges. Over 1.3 million children with disabilities remain largely excluded from the education system – fewer than 12 per cent attend school – making up the majority of Egypt’s estimated 1.5 million out-of-school children. Half of all 12-year-olds lack foundational learning skills, putting them at high risk of dropout. With ongoing neighbouring conflicts, tens of thousands of refugee and vulnerable migrant children are out of school, including 45 per cent of Sudanese arrivals.¹⁵ Overcrowded classrooms, limited WASH facilities, insufficient teaching materials and overstretched teachers place further strain on the public school system.

Within this context, Egypt – through its Vision 2030 and inclusive education policies – prioritizes and is committed to inclusive, quality education for all, including children with disabilities and refugees.

To address all the challenges, UNICEF and the Ministry of Education and Technical Education (MoETE) launched the Comprehensive Inclusion Programme in 2024, integrating disability inclusion, foundational literacy, life skills (aligned with the Life Skills and Citizenship Education framework), refugee rights, child protection, WASH and school governance.

The programme, which is now reaching 275 schools and nearly 389,000 children (49 per cent girls) in Upper Egypt through a holistic, multidimensional model, is building a sustainable, inclusive, safe and quality learning environment for all children by strengthening the education ecosystem at both the policy and school levels.

The Continuous Improvement Plan is being institutionalized through joint efforts by the MoETE and UNICEF, including programme design, accreditation of the training package by the Professional Academy for Teachers, establishing local and national steering committees responsible for needs assessment, planning and monitoring to advance inclusion.

At the school level, the programme uses targeted interventions to improve teaching quality, school infrastructure and student support systems. It addresses literacy, disability inclusion, dropout prevention, and the integration of refugee and migrant children. Key components include structured learning recovery interventions for literacy and a targeted curriculum that supports children with intellectual disabilities to transition into public schools.

At the system and central level, Egypt has made notable strides in governance, quality assurance and educator capacity-building to strengthen the education system's inclusivity and effectiveness. The MoETE has established oversight committees to ensure quality, data management and scalability, and a monitoring system with data and integration to track progress and inform decision-making. A network of master trainers has been created, supported by a mentoring and coaching system along with new performance improvement centres at the *idara* (district) level. Key tools – including a parent guidebook and assessment materials – have been developed to boost student learning and engagement.

At the school level, the programme has reached 275 schools, training 2,000 educators in inclusive education, life skills and social cohesion, while 10,000 teachers across 1,000 schools have been engaged in the targeted literacy programme. To date, over 500,000 students have benefited from these interventions. Strengthened child protection measures, safeguarding and specialized referral pathways are helping children get the support they need. A code of conduct and safe recruitment guidelines for educators have been implemented to maintain ethical teaching standards. Improvements in WASH – such as hygiene promotion and disease prevention – have contributed to a safer and healthier school environment for all students.

The implementation of inclusive education interventions has highlighted the importance of strong governance, institutional coordination and capacity-building in driving sustainable educational reform. Establishing MoETE committees and quality assurance mechanisms has proven essential for ensuring systematic monitoring and scalability. Investing in teacher training, on-the-job mentoring and structured pedagogy has significantly improved educators' ability to support diverse students, particularly those at risk of dropout.

The next phase will scale the Comprehensive Inclusion Programme to 840 public schools, reaching 1.5 million students at the primary and preparatory levels, and expand the National Programme for Improving Literacy Skills to 2,000 schools to better serve marginalized learners. The goal is to develop a cost-effective, sustainable model that can be scaled to all 30,000 schools. Strengthening documentation, assessment and data systems will be central to tracking results, informing policy decisions and refining interventions for greater programme effectiveness.

Ending violence in and around schools

When children are not safe, they cannot learn. Preventing and responding to violence in education systems is fundamental to achieving transformational learning for every child. Safe to Learn, a UNICEF-managed multi-partner global initiative to end violence in and through schools, continues to drive global action by integrating efforts across education, child protection, and social and behaviour change (SBC). Through strategic advocacy and programming, Safe to Learn is mobilizing commitments to end violence in, around and through schools. By leveraging cross-sectoral collaboration across education, child protection and SBC, this work contributed to over 45 countries making concrete pledges to ensure safe and enabling learning environments at the first-ever Ministerial Conference on Violence against Children in November 2024.

UNICEF continued to support education ministries by providing technical support to strengthen safe, inclusive and gender-equitable learning environments. By embedding violence prevention into education systems, UNICEF leverages schools as catalysts for shaping positive social and gender norms that protect children from harm. In **Sri Lanka**, UNICEF is creating a safer, more resilient education system that promotes students' well-being. In 2024, UNICEF trained 200 school principals, 1,173 teachers and 4,700 parents on positive discipline approaches and engaged 10,400 secondary students in initiatives addressing hate speech. These efforts informed Sri Lanka's high-level pledge to scale up the first-ever national teacher training package on positive discipline and endorsement of the Safe to Learn Call to Action at the Ministerial Conference on Violence against Children. **Jordan's** Ministry of Education integrated the Safe to Learn programme into all 3,780 schools, including those in Syrian refugee camps, reinforcing its commitment to safe and inclusive learning environments. Through this initiative, over 2,879 educators (52 per cent females) were trained to identify, prevent and respond to violence against children, strengthening accountability and fostering a culture of safety and protection within schools. Efforts to end violence against children in **Thailand** demonstrated cross-sectoral impact and improved economic productivity, learning outcomes and social protection. To address violence in schools, UNICEF provided technical support to the Ministry of Education, in collaboration with the national Education Safety Centre, to develop Thailand's national Safe to Learn road map. Using the Safe to Learn programmatic

framework and benchmarking tool, this initiative marks a significant step towards safer learning environments for all children.

In addition, schools, teachers, educational personnel and students continued to be targets of increased armed violence throughout 2024. Military use of educational facilities, recruitment of children by armed groups, and targeted attacks on women and girls receiving education were also ongoing. In 2024, UNICEF continued to assist governments to implement the 'Safe Schools Declaration' and 'Guidelines for Protecting Schools and Universities from Military Use in Armed Conflict'. To date, 121 states around the world have endorsed the Safe Schools Declaration,¹⁶ with **Rwanda** signing in 2024. UNICEF support includes developing school safety plans, promoting learning continuity, providing MHPSS and informal learning opportunities, training teachers, rehabilitating schools and delivering social cohesion activities. In **Nigeria**, attacks on education continue to increase. In response, UNICEF trained 3,352 members (28 per cent female) of school-based management committees on the operationalization of the Safe Schools Declaration. The training covered key areas such as school management and disaster risk reduction planning, and equipped members with skills to strengthen school safety and resilience in crisis-affected areas.

Education in emergency coordination: the Global Education Cluster

In 2024, UNICEF and Save the Children continued their co-leadership of the Inter-Agency Standing Committee's Global Education Cluster (GEC). Education clusters and working groups were active in 28 contexts. The GEC bolstered its operational support to education clusters and working groups through 698 days of remote and in-country deployments to support coordination, information management and thematic priorities.

Humanitarian–development–peace nexus

UNICEF's dual focus – rapid emergency response coupled with strategic long-term investment – reflects the humanitarian–development–peace (HDP) nexus in action. In the education sector, UNICEF adopts a comprehensive HDP nexus approach, ensuring that interventions not only meet immediate needs during crises but also contribute to long-term resilience, development and peacebuilding. This integrated approach positions education as both a lifeline during emergencies and a foundation for recovery, inclusion and stability.

In **Ethiopia**, over 89,329 pre-primary students (48 per cent girls) in development and humanitarian settings, and more than 231,464 out-of-school children of primary school age (50 per cent girls) in humanitarian situations accessed equitable, inclusive and quality education with UNICEF support. Notably, 99 per cent of OOSC aged 10–14 who completed accelerated education successfully transitioned to regular primary education, demonstrating the effectiveness of these interventions in restoring learning. This is a successful nexus approach that moved from humanitarian to resilience-building to development.

To strengthen preparedness and resilience, UNICEF supported the training of 546 disaster risk management committees in **Madagascar**, focusing on disaster risk reduction and climate change adaptation. This training enhanced local capacities in coordination, emergency response, data collection, reporting and stock management, laying the groundwork for faster recovery and more robust education systems that can withstand future shocks.

Education also plays a pivotal role in fostering peace and social cohesion, particularly in crisis-affected and displacement settings. In 2024, UNICEF strengthened efforts to bridge humanitarian and development interventions by using education as a tool for stability and inclusion. In **Türkiye**, one of the world's largest refugee-hosting countries, UNICEF's partnerships with municipalities and provincial education directorates enabled 1,338 students (52 per cent girls), including 712 refugees, to participate in school-led activities such as sports tournaments and hobby gardens to strengthen social cohesion.

Social and behaviour change for education

Social and behavioural change (SBC) involves altering attitudes, behaviours and social norms to achieve positive outcomes. In 2024, UNICEF's education programmes increasingly leveraged SBC to shift social norms, engage communities and promote practices that support inclusive learning environments for every child. Compared to the baseline of 40 in 2021, 75 country offices now report employing education-specific SBC strategies. Across diverse contexts, SBC strategies and informed interventions proved essential for strengthening demand for education, improving retention and transforming deeply rooted gender and social norms.

In **Mozambique**, peer mentoring programmes reached 54,100 students, addressing issues such as menstrual hygiene management and violence prevention. School clubs and council initiatives demonstrated effectiveness in reducing absenteeism and strengthening community accountability for school outcomes. Back-to-school campaigns launched in collaboration with national authorities helped re-engage learners following periods of interrupted attendance, reinforcing the right to education.

In **Peru**, SBC-driven initiatives empowered 39,873 adolescents to participate in education decision-making. The Secondary Education as a Life Experience model, scaled to 265 schools, promoted student engagement and well-being, while the 'Brillando Perú' programme trained children and communities in advocacy and leadership. An inclusive education toolbox provided teachers, families and students with practical tools to promote inclusion, especially in linguistically and culturally diverse regions.

In **Jamaica**, SBC interventions focused on MHPSS, as well as behaviour change at scale. More than 1,000 teachers were trained in MHPSS following Hurricane Beryl, and 63 community care groups were established to provide emotional support and help strengthen children's resilience. The expansion of the Positive Behavior Intervention and Support framework to over 60 per cent of schools marked a system-wide shift in promoting positive discipline and supportive school climates.

Together, these examples show how SBC is catalysing the transformation of education by promoting inclusion, well-being and safer schools while amplifying children's and communities' voices in shaping education systems.

Education transforms lives, starting with healthy, happy and safe learners

Healthy, well-nourished children and young people learn more effectively and are more likely to lead productive lives as adults. Investing in their health, nutrition and well-being is essential to achieve inclusive and equitable quality education. Those who receive a quality education tend to be healthier throughout their lives, and healthy individuals are more likely to excel academically.

In 2024, UNICEF, in partnership with UNESCO, published the 'Building Strong Foundations' series of briefs,¹⁷ providing evidence-based guidance to ministries of education, curriculum developers, policymakers, school management and educators to support primary school-aged children stay in school, keep safe and grow up healthy to lead thriving lives. The initiative had an immediate impact through targeted teacher capacity-building. The ongoing collaboration with the Inter-Agency Group for School Health and Nutrition, which includes UNICEF, UNESCO, the Food and Agriculture Organization of the United Nations, GPE, the UN Nutrition Secretariat, the World Food Programme, the World Health Organization, the World Bank and the Research Consortium on School Health and Nutrition, has led to the development of two key documents: (1) 'Transforming Education through Health and Well-Being: Briefing Note'; and (2) 'Integrating Health and Well-Being into Education Sector Policy and Planning: A Handbook' (to be published in 2025). These documents aim to assist countries in integrating health and well-being into their education sector planning.

Recognizing the transformative potential of an integrated approach to school health and nutrition, UNICEF collaborates with governments and partners to prioritize learners' health within the education agenda. For example, in **Indonesia**, the UNICEF-supported 'Aksi Bergizi' programme has expanded gender-responsive adolescent nutrition initiatives, benefiting over 12 million children. Furthermore, UNICEF assisted the Indonesian Government in launching a costed road map for WASH in schools, which aims to improve WASH infrastructure, aligning with the new administration's priorities. This initiative also included a national-level assessment of WASH facilities and services in schools.

In **Mexico**, UNICEF successfully advocated for amendments to the General Education Law to ban the sale of low-nutritional-value foods in schools. Additionally, in **Moldova**, UNICEF initiated infrastructure projects in 124 schools to assess and enhance WASH facilities and co-chaired the WASH in Schools Sector Coordination Council.



Rinah binti Rai, 8, participates in a nutrition assessment exercise conducted by UNICEF at her school in Malaysia in June 2024.

Results achieved in Goal Area 2 Results Area 2: Improved learning, skills, participation and engagement for all children and adolescents

Children and young people are growing up in a transforming world. UNICEF helps prepare them for the future by providing opportunities for them to develop knowledge and skills, including life skills, digital skills, transferable skills, and vocational skills for specific jobs.

In 2024, 17.5 million children received individual learning materials through UNICEF-support programmes, including 4.8 million in humanitarian settings, bringing the total number of children reached to 119 million since the beginning of the Strategic Plan 2022–2025 period.

In addition, 31 per cent of 84 reporting countries had an effective teacher development system in 2024, 54 per cent of 78 reporting countries had effective student and community participation, and 44 per cent of 90 reporting countries established gender-responsive systems. Since 2021, 113 million children accessed education through a digital platform supported by UNICEF. These results must accelerate to meet UNICEF's Strategic Plan targets for 2025.

TABLE 4. Progress against Strategic Plan Results Area 2 output-level indicators

Results/ Output-level indicators		2021 Baseline	2024 Value	2025 Target	
2.2.1	Effective teacher development system (percentage of countries)	17	31	75	Gap
2.2.2	Effective learning assessment system (percentage of countries)	39	57	67	On track
2.2.3	Effective student and community participation (percentage of countries)	53	54	76	Gap
2.2.4	Effective system for digital learning solutions (percentage of countries)	9	26	26	Achieved
2.2.5	Gender-responsive systems (percentage of countries)	41	44	78	Gap
2.2.6	Institutionalizing holistic skills development (percentage of countries)	21	42	42	Achieved
2.2.7	Number of children provided with learning materials (millions)	42	119	91	Achieved
2.2.8	Number of children accessed education through digital platforms (millions)	63	113	149	Gap
2.2.9	Number of school management committees capacitated (thousands)	86	429	402	Achieved
2.2.10	Number in or leading civic engagement initiatives (millions)	20	23	25	On track

The proportion of countries with more than 60 per cent of children reaching the minimum proficiency in reading and mathematics in early grades, at the end of primary and at the end of lower secondary education remains desperately

low (i.e., less than 10 per cent in lower secondary). Accelerated efforts are required to effectively address the learning crisis.

TABLE 5. Percentage of countries with more than 60 per cent of children reaching the minimum level of proficiency in reading and mathematics, 2022–2024

Outcome level indicator 2.6: Percentage of countries with more than 60 per cent of children reaching the minimum level of proficiency in reading and mathematics	Disaggregation	No. of countries reporting (2024)	2022	2023	2024	Milestone (2025)	Target (2030)
	Early grades	44	39%	38%	43%	64%	100%
	End of primary	89	22%	26%	28%	60%	100%
	End of lower secondary	59	12%	9%	8%	54%	100%

Key partners: GPE, UNESCO and the World Bank.

Learning in early years

High-quality early childhood education lays the foundations for inclusive, gender-responsive and equitable education outcomes. UNICEF supported 69 per cent of the more than 120 reporting countries to develop strong systems and deliver quality pre-primary education in 2024. Targeted support by country teams to strengthen ECE systems enabled 91 per cent of countries to establish a strong policy environment for early learning. With this enabling support, 79 per cent of countries reported a high-quality teaching-learning environment, while 68 per cent met the benchmarks for governance systems for ECE in 2024. The emerging best practices and lessons learned have also enabled UNICEF to make strong contributions to the organization's Vision for Early Childhood Development,¹⁸ promoting access to pre-primary education, parenting support and the transition of young learners to primary education as part of a comprehensive multisectoral approach.

Recognizing that future financing scenarios for education will be largely dependent on domestic allocations, UNICEF is working with partners to jointly create evidence-based frameworks and tools to position ECE in sector planning and accountability mechanisms. Leveraging scaling research, UNICEF's global ECE programming has strengthened knowledge mobilization and capacity-building

for key stakeholders at global, regional and national levels to promote cost and financing analysis of ECE priorities for inclusion in education sector plans. A transformative tool in this effort, the ECE Accelerator Simulation Model,¹⁹ has been used to empower policymakers with data-driven solutions to expand and sustain ECE services globally. For example, in **Malawi**, the model played a pivotal role in integrating plans for pre-primary expansion through existing public schools. The government leveraged the tool to address disparities, create scalable frameworks, and prioritize resource allocation for vulnerable populations. In **Pakistan**, provincial-level planning efforts used the model to align local ECE strategies with national objectives. The tool provided cost projections and actionable insights, enabling stakeholders to plan for universal pre-primary education effectively. Similarly, **Namibia** has adopted elements of the tool to enhance its national education sector strategy, ensuring that ECE priorities align with long-term development goals. The ECE Accelerator Simulation Model also empowered policymakers in countries such as **Türkiye**, where it supported the development of a national investment case, strengthening donor engagement and funding discussions.

Driving global commitments and thought leadership, UNICEF collaborated with UNESCO to co-publish the 'Global Report on Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE): The right to a strong foundation'. This flagship

report, developed in response to the 2022 Tashkent Declaration and Commitments to Action for Transforming ECCE, offers evidence-based policy recommendations for leveraging parents, families, educators and communities to improve learning outcomes, and outlines a comprehensive road map for addressing global challenges through an integrated early childhood ecosystem that supports children and families worldwide.

Quality ECE during the crucial period of brain growth and skills development in a child's early years is critical for achieving foundational learning – basic literacy, numeracy and socio-emotional skills – that predicts later educational success. Research shows that children who attend quality ECE programmes have better early literacy, numeracy and social skills, leading to higher school readiness,

improved Grade 1 retention, reduced dropout rates, and stronger academic performance through primary school. Economic analyses demonstrate that investing in ECE yields high returns, saving on later education and social costs. Neglecting ECE risks lower school readiness, higher dropout rates, missed developmental opportunities and widening inequalities, particularly affecting disadvantaged children.²⁰ Following the evidence aligning ECE provision with improved foundational learning, UNICEF designed and piloted the Country Action Tracker (CATch ECE) tool, enhancing accountability for government-led plans for sustainable ECE expansion. Based on preliminary results across 89 countries in the first round, the tool is being further refined to incorporate inclusion benchmarks. These achievements underscore UNICEF's commitment to transforming early learning landscapes worldwide.



On 26 November 2024, in remote areas of Jurm District, Badakhshan province, Afghanistan, children learn in a UNICEF-supported community-based education (CBE) class. CBE classes play a crucial role in providing educational opportunities to children who might otherwise be unable to attend formal schools. The CBE classes are designed to bring education to rural communities, offering children a chance to learn new skills, broaden their horizons, and build a brighter future.

Foundational learning

Foundational learning provides building blocks in a child's learning journey, offering basic literacy, numeracy and socio-emotional skills that children need to thrive throughout their lives. Without these skills, children struggle to thrive in school and are more likely to drop out. At a national level, a lack of foundational learning skills can lead to greater youth unemployment and deeper levels of poverty. Nevertheless, 6 out of every 10 students fail to meet the minimum learning proficiency by the end of primary school – a devastating reality at the heart of the learning crisis.

In 2024, UNICEF continued to lead global efforts to tackle the learning crisis and accelerate foundational learning outcomes for all children, including children with disabilities and those located in remote or emergency situations.

In collaboration with the Global Coalition for Foundational Learning,²¹ UNICEF drove collective action to mitigate the learning crisis by supporting countries to adopt evidence-based solutions, strengthen data systems and advance policy advocacy. These efforts culminated in 39 governments and 38 organizations endorsing the Commitment to Action on Foundational Learning²² in 2024 – up from 16 in 2022. The Commitment to Action aims to halve learning poverty by 2030. High-profile convenings supported by UNICEF – at the 79th United Nations General Assembly, the African Union Continental Education Conference in Mauritania and the African Foundational Learning Exchange in Rwanda – further galvanized momentum, showcased country-led innovations and deepened regional cooperation.

UNICEF played a pivotal role in supporting education systems to scale foundational learning globally. Through the Scaling Remedial Education Programme, supported by the Gates Foundation, UNICEF provided targeted technical guidance to 17 countries²³ in sub-Saharan Africa, helping governments embed evidence-based remedial approaches into national education systems. For example, **Ghana's** Differentiated Learning Plus (DL+) programme addresses the learning crisis through the evidence-based Teaching at the Right Level (TaRL) approach, which tailors instruction to each student's ability level rather than age. The DL+ Dashboard consolidates assessment data, provides real-time insights and empowers stakeholders at all levels to make data-driven decisions.²⁴ Additionally, the launch of the Foundational Learning Action Tracker (FLAT)²⁵ in 2024

reinforced system-level accountability, equipping countries with data-driven tools to monitor progress, inform policy decisions and sustain political commitment.

Developed by UNICEF with support from the Hempel Foundation, the FLAT highlights change for children and impact on their learning from 2023 to 2024. Implementing mechanisms to collect information, notably on student attendance and dropout, and assessing learning levels, is crucial for improving learning. According to the FLAT, 67 per cent of countries reported collecting information on student attendance and dropout at the primary level nationwide, marking an improvement on the 55 per cent of countries reporting this in 2023. To help improve instruction through better monitoring of learning, the proportion of countries providing teachers with support on assessments of foundational learning increased substantially from 21 per cent in 2023 to 43 per cent in 2024. Recognizing the importance of structured pedagogy, targeted instruction and catch-up learning to increase the efficiency of instruction, 48 per cent of reporting countries implemented structured pedagogy nationwide, against 24 per cent in 2023.

Non-formal and remedial learning in emergency settings

Emergency situations, including attacks on education and climate change and extreme weather-induced emergencies, demonstrated the need for increased scalability of non-formal education, remedial learning and accelerated learning programmes that measure learning. In **Afghanistan**, UNICEF enabled 564,434 children (64 per cent girls) to access community-based education, established within 3 kilometres of their communities. In **Haiti**, where over 30 per cent of official learning time was lost due to prolonged school closures, UNICEF provided technical and financial support for catch-up classes, benefiting 58,182 students (55 per cent girls) in examination grades. These efforts resulted in a 60 per cent success rate in year-end exams and helped students regain lost learning and advance in their education despite disruptions.

Secondary education, skills development and learning to earning

While efforts to improve access to education continued in 2024, progress at the lower and upper secondary levels remained inconsistent, with poorer regions experiencing lower completion rates. Many young people, especially those who are out of school, girls, and young people with disabilities, lack the necessary foundational, transferable, digital, green, entrepreneurial and job-specific skills needed to navigate personal, social and economic challenges. Recent data indicate that 20.4 per cent of young people globally remain not in employment, education or training (NEET)²⁶ – a figure that has shown little improvement in recent years. Out of the 272 million out-of-school children and young people, 130 are at the upper secondary level²⁷ reinforcing the urgency for continued investment in skills development to equip young people for school, work and life.

To address these challenges, UNICEF expanded its initiatives to 92 countries in 2024, up from 86 countries in 2023, collaborating with partners to strengthen national secondary education systems and create multiple flexible learning pathways for adolescents such as bridging, accelerated and catch-up programmes. These interventions aim to reintegrate out-of-school young people into learning and improve their employability by integrating comprehensive skills development into curricula, including technical and vocational education and training (TVET).

To that effect, UNICEF supported the expansion of skills programming through curriculum reforms in over 15 countries in 2024 to align national education systems with the demands of the 21st-century economy. In **Kyrgyzstan**, a major education reform introduced a 12-year schooling system and competency-based curricula that emphasize inclusive and climate-resilient learning. **Uzbekistan** approved new curriculum standards integrating socio-emotional learning, digital and green skills, and gender-responsive education. In **Belize**, a nationwide roll-out of a competency-based curriculum focused on foundational and transferable skills reached all primary and secondary schools, with 95 per cent of teachers receiving training. **Armenia** continued the roll-out of a new national curriculum, including health and life-skills components.

In **Peru**, UNICEF strengthened secondary education by implementing the Secondary Education as a Life Experience model in 265 schools, directly benefiting over 120,000 adolescents. The initiative aligned with national policies promoting adolescent reintegration and retention in school. Capacity building was provided to 125 regional specialists on the national Guiding Framework for supporting adolescents, and the ECW programme

complemented these efforts by improving school infrastructure and support systems, enhancing access and quality of education for students in crisis-affected areas

In **Madagascar**, UNICEF supported 1,593 secondary school teachers (72 per cent women) in building competencies for teaching scientific subjects and promoting STEM education, particularly for girls. This initiative also included rehabilitating and constructing classrooms in junior secondary schools, equipping them with computers and internet connectivity. This effort expanded access to digital learning for 127,386 learners. Additionally, school governance was enhanced through the training of over 3,700 school management committee members, while secondary education financing was bolstered via UNICEF's role in a pooled education fund, which disbursed grants to nearly 2,000 lower secondary schools, impacting 489,064 students.

Catalysed by UNICEF's Generation Unlimited (GenU), a public-private youth partnership platform, additional programmes focused on learning-to-earning, providing young people with pathways to decent work and entrepreneurship.

In **India**, 1.87 million young people were trained in digital skilling through GenU's Passport to Earning (P2E) programme in 2024. Cumulatively, over 4 million young people across India have gained certified digital skills through P2E since 2022. Additionally, the Step-Up programme provided targeted career training for 315,087 job seekers, and the YouthHub portal facilitated 277,000 employment, internship, upskilling and volunteering opportunities to bridge the gap between education and the workforce.

In **Brazil**, the One Million Opportunities initiative, also catalysed by GenU, expanded career pathways for vulnerable young people, connecting 311,000 of them to apprenticeships, internships and employment opportunities. UNICEF's Seal initiative successfully placed 85,600 adolescents from the most vulnerable regions in job vacancies, while UNICEF's Successful School Pathways programme improved educational access and learning outcomes for 35,000 students.

In 2024, the UPSHIFT skills development initiative expanded to 56 countries, engaging 2.1 million young people, with 1.1 million completing the full learning journey and earning certification. In **Iraq**, UNICEF trained 10,092 young people in life skills, digital literacy, entrepreneurship and employability. This initiative enabled 504 young people to launch their own businesses, and 204 to secure internships and apprenticeships, demonstrating the transformative potential of skills development in youth empowerment.

CASE STUDY: Advancing adolescent empowerment and skilling to end child marriage in Odisha, India



Sarpanch Sasmita Kumari Sahoo and Advika Group members lead a campaign rally against child marriage in their village in Odisha, India.

'ADVIKA – I am Unique' programme was launched by Government of Odisha in partnership with UNICEF-UNFPA in October 2020.

Odisha, India – home to over 8.3 million adolescents – has a child marriage prevalence of 20.5 per cent, driven by poverty, limited access to education, and harmful gender norms. As the state with the third-largest tribal population (40 per cent), children in tribal and rural areas face even greater risks due to school dropouts, poor infrastructure and social pressures – all exacerbated by environmental shocks such as heatwaves and cyclones.

To address these challenges and empower girls across Odisha, UNICEF and the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), in partnership with the Department of Women and Children, launched 'Advika: I Am Unique', a life skills platform aimed at ending child marriage and all forms of violence against adolescent girls, in 2019.

Advika has proven effective as a multi-pronged adolescent programme combining strong community engagement and high political commitment to promote life skills at scale. It successfully transitioned to a government-led scheme in 2023.

The initiative's strategy and implementation includes:

- Empowering adolescents: Advika engages adolescent girls and boys to increase their awareness on child rights, gender, nutrition, and sexual and reproductive health, and build life skills and employability, through weekly Advika sessions held in Anganwadi centres in communities. It also identifies and trains adolescent girls aged 10–19 as peer leaders to promote leadership and learning.
- Community engagement and transformation: Advika focuses on mobilizing community members through self-help groups and local institutions, reaching women, men, adolescent girls and boys, and traditional leaders to create an enabling environment for addressing harmful practices.
- Systems-strengthening: Aligning with the State Strategic Action Plan to end child marriage, structured cascaded training is conducted for district-level stakeholders across departments and front-line workers. District task forces plan and review actions to end child marriage, with regular monitoring and review systems being embedded. The strategy also includes the integration of adolescent sexual and reproductive health services.

As a positive demonstration of local ownership, Advika was adopted by the State of Odisha with a budget of INR 500 million (US\$5.8 million) over five years (2023–2028) to cover the implementation of the initiative across all districts. This involves training over 448,000 Anganwadi workers, 300,000 peer leaders, government officials and civil society partners. Resources support training, awareness-raising campaigns, monitoring and service linkages. UNICEF and UNFPA continue to provide technical support by leveraging the resources available for implementation of the initiative.

The programme's progress and results as of 2024:

- Over 5.2 million adolescents in Odisha were engaged in life-skills training to prevent child marriage and school dropout, as well as to promote career readiness and skilling.
- Around 600,000 community members, 90,000 women from women-led self-help groups and 60,000 men and boys were supported to promote continuity of education and help children stay in school, prevent child marriage and ensure an enabling environment for adolescents' future pathways.
- Over 80,000 adolescents accessed protective and other preventive services, including scholarships for higher education.
- Over 200,000 religious and community leaders and 600,000 community members were engaged in gender equality dialogues, advocacy and consensus-building on alternatives to child marriage (including education), the rights of adolescent girls and gender equality.
- Around 100,000 vulnerable children were identified across all districts, with more than 54,000 children (28,000 girls) linked to essential social protection schemes to ensure continuity of education and prevent child marriage.

Advika's peer leader model has helped engage boys and young men on masculinity and related behaviours. However, programmes for girls and boys require different approaches. Alternative approaches, such as sports for development, should be explored to engage boys and create mixed-gender spaces. Low male participation remains a challenge, but efforts are underway to expand the programme to include boys, using life skills to address harmful male behaviours. Additionally, the Advika mobile app – created to build life skills and support adolescents' career readiness – has had limited reach due to low digital access, particularly among girls.

Future efforts will focus on refining approaches for working with adolescent boys, implementing a child vulnerability mapping across the state, and identifying adolescent 'champions'. Plans are also in place to strengthen the Advika programme by improving the quality of weekly sessions and using digital tools for career readiness.

Gender-responsive education systems for learning and skills development

In 2024, UNICEF continued to advance gender-responsive education systems, with 44 per cent of 90 reporting countries achieving the indicator, up from 36 per cent in 2023 – an 8 per cent increase, although short of the 69 per cent target for 2024. UNICEF's strategies, including gender-inclusive curricula and learning assessments, reached over 10 million adolescents, including 52 per cent girls, across 60 countries in 2024. This progress, driven by partnerships with the United Nations Girls' Education Initiative (UNGEI) and investments in teacher training and digital platforms, reflects a commitment to equitable learning opportunities. Yet funding gaps and cultural barriers to girls' skills development, especially in secondary education, persist.

Regionally, sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia progressed, with 75 per cent of Eastern and Southern African countries meeting the indicator on gender-responsive systems, driven by community-based models, although the Middle East and North Africa lagged behind (30 per cent achievement) due to the impacts of conflict.

In 2024, UNICEF made significant strides in closing the digital gender divide. UNICEF empowered 374 girls through the Education Innovation Challenge, piloted in **South Africa** and **Sierra Leone**. About 31,000 girls gained digital skills through The AI Forward Alliance.

Supported by UNICEF, **Benin's** national programme to improve girls' education and well-being enhanced gender-responsive education for girls. The programme provided cash transfers to 100,160 girls aged 9–15 in northern Benin, boosting retention and reintegration. In **Indonesia**, in partnership with national and subnational partners, UNICEF expanded life-skills and 21st-century skills programmes, reaching over 19,000 girls across 56 districts. This initiative, informed by UNICEF's 2024 Gender Programmatic Review, used gender-responsive planning and budgeting to address girls' barriers.

Complementary opportunities are particularly critical for girls, who often face multiple barriers to accessing education. Through 2,087 Alternative Learning Programme centres, UNICEF **Pakistan** reached 93,986 marginalized children (56 per cent girls), including refugees, with vocational training. The programme reached 13,361 youth (59 per cent girls), with 70 per cent transitioning to employment. Training in gender-responsive methods was provided to 13,548 teachers (52 per cent female). This helped address cultural barriers to learning and skills development, aligning with national priorities.

Housed in UNICEF, UNGEI is a global partnership that galvanizes action globally for girls' education and gender equality in and through education. One of UNGEI's platforms²⁸ is the Gender at the Centre Initiative (GCI).²⁹ In 2024, GCI supported 350 Ministry of Education (MoE) staff and civil society actors from 9 countries to enable

recognition and analysis of existing gender barriers in education, develop gender-inclusive budgets, policies and curricula, and build leadership skills for gender equality. Supported by training and technical assistance from GCI, **Mali** developed a five-year costed Gender Action Plan for the MoE, outlining concrete strategies and actions to advance girls' education and gender equality through the education system. Tangible gender strategies were also included in the new GPE-supported programme for Mali. Through its Gender Equality Snapshot Toolkit,³⁰ UNGEI supported the **Central African Republic** to better understand gender inequalities in its education system,³¹ leading to tangible policy changes such as the country's first-ever girls' education policy. In **Mali, Niger and Nigeria**, UNGEI supported the development of feminist youth coalitions, bringing together young gender equality activists for joint advocacy, community outreach and peer support. In **Mali and Niger**, the coalitions are now officially represented in government-led local education groups, bringing young feminist voices to the education decision-making table. For example, the Mali Feminist Youth Coalition participated as a formal advisory body in a high-level government meeting, which led to the adoption of several gender-sensitive strategies.

Tackling gender-based violence was also a key programme focus in 2024. The End School-Related Gender-Based Violence programme in **Sierra Leone**, a collaboration between UNGEI and UNICEF, reached 147,246 adolescents (9 per cent of the national adolescent population). Key results include significant reductions in the proportion of students reporting feeling unsafe (from 13 per cent to 2 per cent) and incidents of sexual violence (from 85 per cent to 52 per cent). Positive gender attitudes increased five-fold, while the number of students who believe that rape should be kept secret decreased. In collaboration with the Sexual Violence Research Initiative, UNGEI published the White Paper on Sexual Violence in Education Settings,³² the first dedicated evidence-based review of sexual violence in and around schools.

UNGEI's Ending Gender Stereotypes in Classrooms through Play-Based Curriculum programme expanded in **India, Niger and Pakistan**, reaching 9,368 learners. Results showed significant shifts in attitudes to gender stereotypes.³³ For example, 93 per cent of girls and 92 per cent of boys associated the word 'cooking' with both genders rather than just girls, compared to 17 per cent of girls and 13 per cent of boys in the baseline survey in **India**.

These initiatives continue to demonstrate UNICEF's impact in strengthening gender-responsive education systems by addressing girls' unique barriers to learning and skills development, such as poverty, cultural norms and lack of access. Results were achieved through teacher training and inclusive programming, paving the way for equitable skills development globally. In the future, UNICEF will prioritize adaptive approaches by supporting governments to blend digital and non-formal education into gender-responsive education systems, close gaps and meet the organization's 2025 Strategic Plan targets, ensuring no child is left behind.



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Girls reading a book on the staircase in Al-Safa Primary School in Basra, Iraq. April 2024.

Strengthening teachers' development and teaching practices

Teachers are at the heart of quality education. Globally, UNICEF works to strengthen teachers' access to high-quality, ongoing professional development tailored to their local context and needs. This includes embedding structured pedagogy and Teaching at the Right Level (TaRL) approaches for strengthening learning outcomes while making education more inclusive and accessible through the promotion of Universal Design for Learning. Additionally, UNICEF advocates for and invests in coaching and mentorship, access to resources, peer support teams and supportive leadership.

Despite this, in 2024, only 31 per cent of countries had effective teacher development systems in place – well below the target of 64 per cent. While mental health and psychosocial support to children is widely recognized as important, a mere 37 per cent of countries reported integrating MHPSS into teachers' professional development opportunities. With only 46 per cent of reporting governments providing incentives for equitable teacher

deployment, inequitable teacher deployment emerged as the main reason for unequal class sizes and learning conditions, disproportionately placing children in rural and marginalized communities and children with disabilities at a disadvantage. Despite these challenges, UNICEF strengthened teacher development in several countries. **Azerbaijan** provided inclusive education training to 1,400 educators, school leaders, psychologists, and educators for children with disabilities, and **Belarus** did so for 4,500 teachers, improving their ability to support children with disabilities.

UNICEF supported the Government of **Guinea** in piloting a programme to improve reading and mathematics outcomes in grades 3, 4 and 5, and trained teachers based on the TaRL approach. Within six months the initiative led to significant progress in French reading and mathematics skills among 1,551 students. In **Ghana, South Africa** and **Zambia**, through an inclusive teacher development programme based on structured pedagogy and TaRL, UNICEF improved learning outcomes for 110,903 learners. UNICEF also advanced the digital transformation of the teaching profession by supporting countries to strengthen teacher preparation, professional development and support systems.

Additionally, teachers who work in humanitarian situations are often overstretched, suffer from trauma, work without payment, and serve a multitude of roles beyond supporting students' learning. In 2024, UNICEF worked to ensure that teachers were supported to continue teaching and received the training they needed. These efforts equipped teachers with the necessary skills to better support learning continuity and the mental health and well-being of students. In **Venezuela**, UNICEF trained 6,560 teachers, including 4,724 women and 694 indigenous, in foundational pedagogy and MHPSS. The training covered strategies for teaching core competencies at early childhood, primary and secondary levels, as well as education for children with disabilities and intercultural bilingual education. The Ministry of Education then expanded the initiative, reaching another 129,184 teachers (93 per cent of women) nationwide.

Digital transformation of education systems and digital learning

In 2024, UNICEF continued advancing digital education to accelerate learning and skills development. Data from 105 countries show that 26 per cent of them have effective systems for digital learning solutions – measured by the quality of digital learning tools, availability of devices, connectivity and youth engagement. This is above the 20 per cent target and represents a steady annual increase from 9 per cent in 2021. Additionally, UNICEF supported 18.3 million children (51 per cent girls) in accessing education through digital platforms, with a focus on making digital learning a public good, accessible to all.

To bridge learning barriers, UNICEF worked with partners to ensure materials are inclusive and accessible to all children – including those with disabilities – through initiatives such as Accessible Digital Textbooks (ADT).³⁴ In 2024, ADT was implemented in 11 countries and provided access to 2 million children, removing barriers and enabling all children, with and without disabilities, to learn in the same classroom. To accelerate scale-up and significantly reduce ADT development time and cost, an AI-powered open-source tool was developed to automate production with OpenAI support. Another targeted initiative focusing on overcoming language barriers for refugees and migrants is the Akelius language learning course. Active in 15 countries, this innovation has rigorous evidence of impact on student outcomes, with children using the Akelius digital language course making significantly greater progress in language learning compared to their peers attending a comparable programme without the digital component.

To address the digital connectivity divide, UNICEF launched Giga with the International Telecommunication Union in 2019, aiming at connecting every school to the internet by 2030. In 2024, Giga expanded to 20 new countries, for a total of 34, mapped 124,000 schools and connected 12 million children to digital learning.

In 2024, UNICEF's Learning Passport – a digital learning programme powered by Microsoft Community Training – expanded to 45 countries, reaching over 9.8 million users, including children, young people and educators, with a total of 5.5 million course completions. This includes supporting digital ECE, primary education, skills development through GenU's Passport to Earning (P2E), teacher training and more. In particular, the P2E programme has, since 2021, equipped adolescents with digital and vocational skills for the future of work. In 2024, it added 2.8 million new users, and over 1.8 million have completed courses and received certificates. This brings the cumulative total results to date to 5.86 million registered P2E learners, with 4 million of them completing courses and receiving certificates, particularly in digital, financial literacy and employability skills. Overall, with 50 per cent female participation and 75 per cent at the primary level, the Learning Passport added 3.8 million new users in 2024, increasing access to flexible, locally relevant and technology-driven learning, especially for children in crisis-affected and marginalized communities. To address connectivity challenges, the Offline Learning Passport was deployed in 10 countries, including **Brazil**, **Mexico**, the **Philippines** and **Zimbabwe**, ensuring uninterrupted learning in low-resource settings.

As emergencies continue to disrupt traditional schooling, digital learning remained a key solution, enabling children to access education and stay engaged. In **Ukraine**, recognizing the growing number of children studying through online modalities, UNICEF expanded its support to the All-Ukrainian School Online platform, enhancing curriculum-linked content in areas where students faced the most significant learning losses. Through this initiative, 884 digitalized lessons were developed, benefiting 245,576 children (49 per cent girls) by providing structured, high-quality educational content tailored to their needs. The Learning Passport also played a vital role in emergencies, supporting displaced children and refugees with tailored education, psychosocial support and safe digital learning environments. Initiatives such as **Honduras's** Travel and Learn and **Lebanon's** Makani and Dirasa programmes reached nearly 35,000 vulnerable learners.

In 2024, UNICEF also strengthened its shift towards human-centred technology integration, empowering teachers, supporting collaborative approaches and bridging gender digital divides. An example is Tinkering with Tech,³⁵ a hands-on learning approach launched in **Honduras**, **Maldives**, **Montenegro** and **Viet Nam** to foster digital and 21st-century skills, creativity and a passion for STEM, particularly among girls. Promising evidence is emerging in **Honduras**, where 73 per cent of students enrolled in the programme demonstrated critical thinking skills, compared to 55 per cent in children not enrolled in the programme; 70 per cent of girls and 68 per cent of boys reported increased interest in STEM. UNICEF also launched the Superstar Teacher Toolbox³⁶ – adaptable modules designed to build teachers' digital pedagogy and AI literacy – for integration into national teacher training programmes.

Joining forces to ensure public education extends into digital and online environments, the Gateways to Public Digital Learning³⁷ expanded from 8 countries in 2023 to 17 by the end of 2024.³⁸ Gateways, led jointly by UNICEF and UNESCO, supports the development of inclusive, high-quality national digital learning platforms and fosters collaboration and knowledge exchange through study visits and webinars. In 2024, study visits hosted by **Egypt** and **Indonesia** welcomed delegates from over 20 countries.

Complementing these efforts, UNICEF provided strategic technical assistance through the Tech4Ed initiative. Supported by GPE, this initiative strengthens countries' capacity to use technology to improve access to education and learning outcomes. In 2024, inception activities were conducted in **Ghana** and **Tajikistan**, identifying key entry-points to strengthen education systems such

as tackling fragmentation of digital initiatives, improving intergovernmental coordination, and enhancing the generation and use of evidence. Six additional countries will join the initiative in 2025.

Lastly, a major milestone for children's education was marked with the launch of UNICEF's new Digital Education Strategy (2025–2030). Designed to significantly accelerate learning outcomes and amplify the global impact of UNICEF's education work, the strategy aligns all digital education efforts around evidence-based approaches that improve learning. At its core, the strategy aims to bridge persistent digital divides – including those related to gender, disability and language – to ensure that every child can benefit from digital transformation.

CASE STUDY: Education in crisis: Digital learning brings hope in Sudan



Children attending an e-learning session at Abdullah Naj internally displaced people's gathering point in Port Sudan, Sudan. June 2024.

After two years of conflict, Sudan faces one of the world's worst humanitarian and education crises, with over 17 million of Sudan's 19 million school-aged children out of school in 2024 – one of the highest out-of-school rates in the world. Most schools remain forcibly closed, and over 3,200 schools are serving as shelters for displaced families.

Sudan's education system faces multiple challenges, exacerbated by conflict, displacement, infrastructure limitations and economic instability – hindering children's right to learn. Amid this crisis, digital learning is providing a critical lifeline.

While digital learning cannot replace traditional schooling, it does offer ways to address some of these challenges by providing flexible, scalable and inclusive solutions to increase access to education and ensure children in emergencies can continue learning, despite school closures and disruptions.

Across 13 states, UNICEF has established 280 digital learning centres. These centres are equipped with solar power, tablets and essential learning materials, offering a safe space for children to continue their education even though most schools are closed. In 2024, the centres reached over 72,000 children (51 per cent girls) aged between 7 and 17 years through two innovative programmes: the Learning Passport and Let Us Learn.

The Learning Passport – a UNICEF digital learning programme that delivers quality, flexible education to children and young people who are displaced, in crisis or otherwise excluded from traditional schooling – enabled continued learning for over 44,000 students in 2024. Using tablets provided by UNICEF in safe learning spaces, students accessed Ministry of Education-approved curricula for grades 1–8 through the Learning Passport platform.

The programme features localized and interactive content designed to promote both academic achievement and socio-emotional well-being. It is zero-rated – meaning learners can access it without incurring data costs – and can be used offline through innovative technology, reducing economic and connectivity barriers and expanding access to even the most remote areas.

By combining localized content, offline functionality and teacher training, the Learning Passport is addressing both immediate and long-term learning needs of Sudan's most marginalized children, including girls, children with disabilities and displaced learners. The Learning Passport not only offers quality educational content but also improves students' and users' digital skills. For teachers, it offers scripted lessons that guide them in conducting blended learning sessions and effectively using digital content to support children's learning.

The Let Us Learn programme provides a gamified, interactive digital version of the Sudanese Alternative Learning Programme – a structured non-formal programme that is designed for children who have been out of school for extended periods or have their learning disrupted – and offers a pathway for them to get back into formal education. Let Us Learn supports children with Arabic, mathematics, information and communications technology, English, culture and science, and MHPSS-related content.

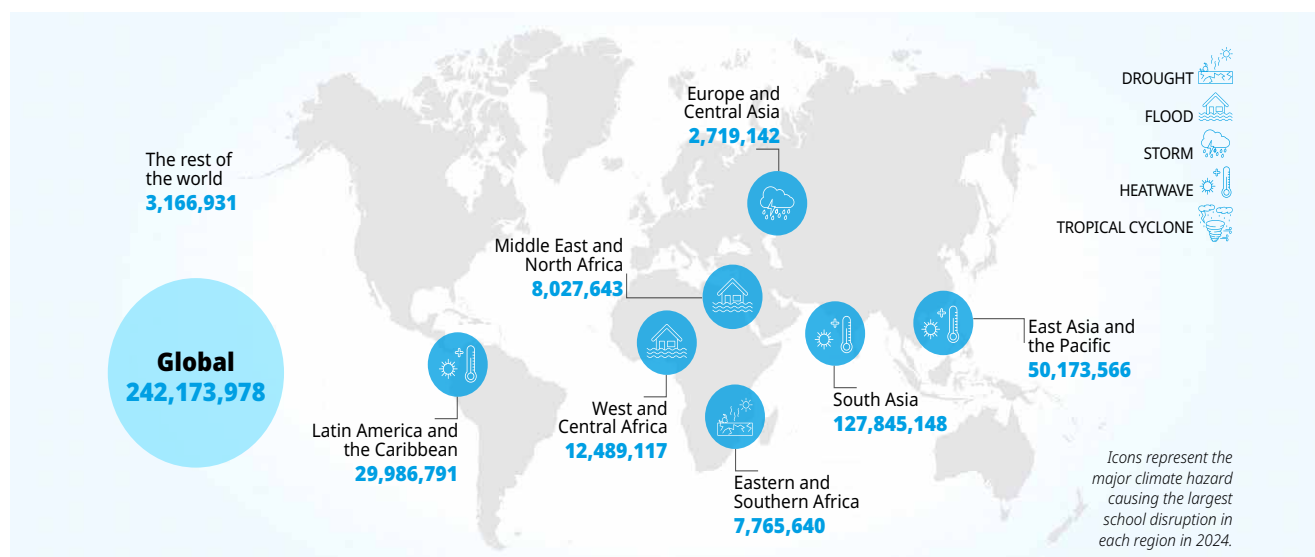
In 2024, Let Us Learn reached over 36,000 children. Over 300 facilitators have also been trained in digital pedagogy and interactive teaching methods, improving learner engagement, support and assessment.

UNICEF is committed to supporting the Government of Sudan in integrating e-learning into national policies and expanding access to digital education. To reach more children – especially those in remote and conflict-affected areas – UNICEF is scaling up the Learning Passport and Let Us Learn, with a target of reaching 500,000 learners by 2025. Strengthening teacher training remains a key priority to address shortages and build capacity, ensuring educators are equipped to use digital tools effectively in their classrooms. UNICEF also plans to develop additional learning content and is exploring digital skills programmes for adolescents and youth, creating pathways from learning to earning in collaboration with non-governmental organizations, the private sector and academia.

The evidence is promising. Children using gamified learning perform 1.7 times better than those without access to the games. UNICEF is investing in further research to understand the effectiveness of digital learning in emergencies, document best practices and identify challenges to help improve the use of digital learning, particularly for marginalized children, in emergency responses.

Environmental sustainability and education

FIGURE 4. Number of students affected by weather- and climate-related school disruptions in 2024, by UNICEF programme region



Source: UNICEF (2025).³⁹

The learning crisis is deeply connected to the environmental crisis.⁴⁰ To spotlight this, UNICEF released *Learning Interrupted*⁴¹ – a 2024 analysis of climate- and weather-driven school disruptions. Data show that at least 242 million children faced climate- and weather-related school disruptions in 2024 alone, deepening the global learning crisis. Bolstering environmental education and green skills tackles both issues simultaneously, as 80 per cent of global business leaders consider these skills essential for the green transition. Yet education captures less than 2 per cent of climate-related development funding.

UNICEF has strengthened its integrated approach to these dual crises, supporting learning continuity during environmental shocks while promoting green skills. Through UNICEF's efforts, the proportion of countries with resilient education systems increased to 40 per cent in 2024 from 23 per cent in 2022, with environmental education now integrated in 91 countries, up from 63.

To foster the resilience of education systems in the face of crises, UNICEF continued efforts to strengthen risk-informed programming through preparedness, prevention, response and mitigation. UNICEF developed practical guidelines for building disaster-resilient schools. The guidelines help schools withstand strong winds, earthquakes and floods, and also address climate change. Guidelines are currently being piloted in **Mozambique**, a country prone to cyclones.

To protect learning against environmental risks, UNICEF both implemented immediate solutions and embedded them in national systems. In **India**, UNICEF worked with the government to integrate environmental action into national curricula and supported state-level efforts such as adolescent eco clubs in over 75,000 schools in Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, integration of disaster management in Kerala, school safety in over 10,000 schools in Gujarat, and youth-led advocacy in Maharashtra. In **Bolivia**, UNICEF implemented solar energy, energy efficiency and rainwater harvesting in schools across seven municipalities and supported the development of government contingency plans for weather- and climate-related events. In **Iraq**, UNICEF implemented green initiatives in 350 schools – promoting sustainability, integrating risk awareness and implementing renewable energy. Building on this model, the government is scaling the initiative across schools nationwide. UNICEF's efforts often bridge multiple government departments, as seen in **North Macedonia**, where UNICEF supported the development of nationwide protocols for schools across the ministries of education and health to ensure learning continuity during heatwaves.

UNICEF's support for adapting education systems includes both formal curricula and opportunities outside the classroom. In **Cambodia**, UNICEF supported the government to expand access to environmentally sensitive education by integrating environmental issues into the local life-skills curriculum and launching a youth solar training programme for adolescents.

UNICEF advocates at national and intergovernmental levels for unified approaches to the learning and environmental crises. This advocacy contributed to the historic inclusion of education in the official Conference of the Parties (COP) Presidency programme. In **Sierra Leone**, a youth-led education manifesto catalysed key government actions, including signing the Declaration on Children, Youth and Climate Action (April 2024) and partnering with UNICEF on developing a national environmentally sensitive curriculum.

UNICEF's approach is built on strong partnerships. UNICEF jointly leads the Systems Capacities Working Group in the Greening Education Partnership alongside UNESCO, GPE and Education International. UNICEF's education work is

strengthened through membership of the Global Alliance for Disaster Risk Reduction and Resilience in the Education Sector, a collaborative platform with UNESCO, the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction, Save the Children and the World Bank.

Children continue to bear the brunt of the environmental crisis. In 2050–2059, children will face eight times more extreme heatwaves and three times more extreme river floods compared to the 2000s. UNICEF is expanding integrated solutions by monitoring school closures, helping governments connect environmental action with education, scaling green schools and developing green skills for employability.



Children at Kolong Primary School in South Africa take part in a reading programme where teachers are supported to teach in mother tongue languages. April 2024.

CASE STUDY: Greening the future: How students in the United Republic of Tanzania are leading climate action

In the United Republic of Tanzania, a total of 673 climate action clubs have been established across 279 secondary and 394 primary schools, benefiting 203,372 students (52 per cent girls).

With UNICEF support, schools receive materials for seedling cultivation, seeds, and training for teachers and administrators on how to establish and manage the clubs. These clubs, each with 15–30 students, equip children and youth with practical green skills and mentorship to tackle issues such as deforestation, pollution and soil erosion. Beyond activities such as recycling and tree planting, the clubs are fundamentally aimed at empowering youth in Tanzania as environmental leaders and advocates.

As the country experiences more heatwaves and torrential rains and floods, the establishment of the clubs responds to a strong demand from children and young people⁴² as a national education priority. A 2023 U-Report survey found that 70 per cent of over 12,000 youth respondents believe their actions can influence climate policy, and 8 in 10 stressed the importance of climate education, yet 3 in 10 reported lacking access to relevant skills to address climate change. Nationally, the World Bank's Country Climate and Development Report⁴³ and the United Republic of Tanzania's new Education Development Strategic Plan also call for building a climate-informed education system. As the Ministry of Education, Science and Training revises its national education policy and curriculum to integrate climate change, these school clubs offer a practical, youth-led platform to build knowledge, skills and action for climate resilience.

In 2024, Kisimani Secondary School launched a climate action club to engage young people in addressing environmental challenges facing their community, with support from UNICEF and partners. The climate action club is proving that young people can be powerful agents of change. By equipping students with green skills, the project is cultivating youth innovators who are tackling environmental challenges directly in their own communities. From recycling plastic waste into useful products to creating organic compost for school gardens, these young leaders are gaining practical green skills and applying them in their everyday lives.

"Our school and community still face challenges like inadequate rain, soil erosion, pollution and lack of community awareness on environment," says Brenda Mwanji, a 16-year-old student. "I joined the club because I knew that this knowledge could help tackle such challenges and even help me learn skills in gardening."

Despite this progress, the school still faces challenges, particularly in accessing reliable water sources. "The school faces challenges with water availability, as it depends on a single source which supplies water to three other schools, which makes it insufficient," says Agripa, a teacher at Kisimani. Sustainable solutions will rely on both continued government support and increased environmental awareness at the community level.



Kisimani Secondary School environment club members in front of their garden in the United Republic of Tanzania, 2024.

Recognizing the value of these clubs, the government is now integrating climate-related activities into the national school curriculum and encourages teachers to promote sustainable environments in the classroom.

Climate action clubs are proof that when young people, communities and organizations come together, real change happens. These clubs are helping embed sustainability into the everyday lives of students and their communities, laying the groundwork for long-term climate resilience.

UNICEF continues to work closely with partners, through the Every Adolescent Girl Learns programme, and the United Republic of Government of Tanzania to equip children, young people and teachers with tools to address environmental challenges. The programme will be progressively scaled to all schools nationwide, alongside the development of a gender-responsive climate action curriculum for secondary education – including teacher development resources and student learning materials – set to be piloted in early 2026.



Environment club members showcase their food garden at their school. United Republic of Tanzania, 2024.



9-year old Anika Cerezo (right) takes part in English course at a school in Guatemala City, Guatemala. February 2024.

Mental health at the heart of learning: Advancing school-based mental health and psychosocial support

In 2024, UNICEF made significant strides in supporting governments to integrate mental health and psychosocial support policies and service delivery in schools and other learning spaces, demonstrating its continued commitment to advancing child rights and improving learning outcomes. The number of UNICEF country offices reporting on this agenda increased from 60 in early 2022 to 80 by the end of 2024. Notably, 41 per cent of reporting countries met key performance benchmarks, highlighting growing global recognition of the essential role that MHPSS plays in enhancing student mental health, engagement, retention and academic achievement. During this period, approximately 2 million children and young people benefited from UNICEF-supported school-based MHPSS interventions. In **Türkiye**, a large-scale initiative trained 41,942 school counsellors in psychosocial support interventions, reaching approximately 1.5 million students, including 384,209 refugee children.

The integration of MHPSS interventions within humanitarian education responses is a core component of UNICEF's work to protect young learners from the adverse effects of crisis and adversity. In 2024, in conflict-affected and disaster-prone contexts, such as **Ethiopia, Haiti, Lebanon** and **Sudan**, UNICEF and partners trained teachers to deliver non-specialized support and adopt psychosocially responsive teaching practices that helped children recover from adversity and continue their education. Support was also extended to school-based MHPSS professionals to ensure the availability of targeted and sustained mental health care. For example, in **Syria**, psychosocial support was provided to 48,385 children (50 per cent girls), while 967 teachers, including 475 women, were trained to support the mental health and well-being of students and staff affected by conflict.

UNICEF reinforced its position as a global leader in MHPSS integration by spearheading the development of high-impact guidance and reference materials designed to support both internal teams and external partners. Key achievements included the release of a cost-benefit analysis of school-based MHPSS interventions⁴⁴ and a comprehensive compendium of resources to inform policy implementation.⁴⁵

In the Middle East and North Africa region, UNICEF developed two mental health literacy guides: one designed for youth aged 16–24, and another for practitioners. These resources were grounded in formative research facilitated

by Youth Participatory Action Researchers and involved 240 participants. The youth guide offers interactive content to help young people recognize and manage mental health challenges and understand how to seek support. The companion guide for practitioners equips educators, social workers and front-line professionals with tools to better support the mental health needs of the young people in their care.

Strategic partnerships have played a pivotal role in accelerating the scale-up of MHPSS globally. UNICEF co-chaired influential global working groups such as the Inter-Agency Network for Education in Emergencies (INEE) psychosocial support and social and emotional learning working group, and joined forces with key partners, including the LEGO Foundation and the Z Zurich Foundation, to drive innovative and impactful programming. For example, through a comprehensive toolbox, the Thriving Together partnership between UNICEF and the Z Zurich Foundation supports campaigns and interventions across 15 countries to strengthen the mental health of adolescents and their caregivers, addressing three key environments – family, school and community – and places special emphasis on equipping teachers with the tools and skills needed to promote student well-being and create nurturing learning environments. Since its inception in September 2021, Thriving Together has positively impacted the lives of more than 900,000 adolescents and caregivers. The aim is to support at least 11 million people by 2027.



Primary school students learn during a class in Kabul, Afghanistan. June 2024.

Data and evidence

In 2024, UNICEF deepened its engagement in data and evidence, specifically on accountability tracking, household data and learning assessment, and data usage. In 113 countries, UNICEF accompanied governments in implementing evidence-based education sector plans and strategies mainstreaming the SDG indicators.

On accountability tracking, the Foundational Learning Action Tracker (FLAT)⁴⁶ expanded data coverage to 123 low- and middle-income countries (up from 120 in 2023), with 115 countries (up from 101 in 2023) reporting on all dimensions under the RAPID framework.⁴⁷ It produced 30 country scorecards, 7 regional briefs and 2 African snapshots. FLAT insights influenced 5 national education policy discussions and were showcased at 18 global and regional events. The FLAT has become a key accountability tool, driving government awareness and action on foundational learning. In 2024, the Country Action Tracker for Children – Early Childhood Education (CATCh-ECE) was piloted within the FLAT exercise, engaging 89 countries.

On household data and learning assessment, five countries measured learning through a Multiple Indicator Cluster Survey (MICS),⁴⁸ and seven conducted the Southeast Asia Primary Learning Metrics (SEA-PLM)⁴⁹ in 2024 – both government-led and UNICEF-supported initiatives. UNICEF also supported national assessment systems and collaborated with stakeholders, including the PAL Network, to improve the availability of foundational learning data. In addition, UNICEF supported 8 countries in conducting diagnostics through MICS – Education Analysis for Global Learning and Equity (MICS-EAGLE), now active in 30 countries, and piloted MICS-Link, integrating household and education management information system data in **Fiji, Eswatini and Vanuatu**, with further expansion focused on co-creation and capacity development.

On data usage, UNICEF's Data Must Speak (DMS)⁵⁰ research contributed to advance data-informed decision-making in education across more than 15 countries. In **Côte d'Ivoire** and **Ghana**, ministries incorporated DMS findings into national reforms, introducing unique school IDs and embedding insights in strategic policy documents and GPE funding applications. In **Madagascar** and **Zambia**, DMS strengthened local capacities through hands-on co-creation and data analysis. In **Togo** and **Nepal**, the research influenced sector plans and gender-responsive strategies. Cited in global reports by UNESCO and the World Bank, DMS continues to unlock the power of administrative data, empowering governments to identify what works and scale local solutions to improve learning outcomes.

Adolescent and youth development and participation

In 2024, UNICEF worked to strengthen local and national systems to ensure at-scale, sustained support for meaningful and safe adolescent engagement. This approach helped achieve important results, including new laws, policies and programmes. UNICEF, together with governments, engaged 22.7 million adolescents (58 per cent girls) across 101 countries in taking action to address issues affecting their lives, with 1.8 million of these adolescents in a humanitarian context. The number of young people engaged in development remained stable between 2023 and 2024 at 20.9 million per year, against a Strategic Plan target of 25.3 million. In humanitarian settings, UNICEF reached 800,000 adolescents, demonstrating UNICEF's sustained support for young people's ability to respond to crises. Among those engaged, 41 per cent were aged 10–14; 37 per cent were 15–19; and 23 per cent were 20–24. UNICEF also made steady progress in enhancing systems-strengthening for adolescent and youth engagement, with 61 per cent of UNICEF country offices establishing and using platforms that drive results at scale.

Countries around the world exemplify this progress.

India mobilized over 13 million adolescents in various initiatives through UNICEF-supported state government platforms such as Advika (Odisha Girls' Empowerment Programme) and Kanyashree Clubs (girls' clubs). In **Türkiye**, nearly 390,000 young people were engaged through youth centres and provincial child committees across all 81 provinces. In **Brazil**, over 54,000 adolescents participated in adolescent citizenry centres, collaborating with local authorities to advance child rights. In **Uganda**, with UNICEF's support, the government established children's reference groups as a platform for adolescent participation in decision-making, governance and civic engagement, reaching 16,000 young people through campaigns addressing child marriage, teenage pregnancy, and adolescent health and nutrition.

Schools played a pivotal role in fostering youth participation, with initiatives such as the integration of life-skills education in **Ethiopia**, which reached over 46,000 young people. Youth engagement programmes in countries such as **Armenia, Colombia, Côte d'Ivoire, the Democratic Republic of Congo, Ecuador, Egypt, Jordan, Mali, Mexico, Papua New Guinea, Viet Nam and Zimbabwe** further collectively impacted hundreds of thousands of

young people. These initiatives included scaling adolescent responses to flooding, conflict resolution and participation in local governance, and significantly enhanced youth mobilization and empowerment.

Despite escalating conflicts, chronic displacement, food insecurity, disease outbreaks and natural disasters, UNICEF's adolescent and youth programming in humanitarian settings in 2024 achieved significant milestones. In **Ukraine**, 106,535 young volunteer leaders were trained to support humanitarian efforts, including distributing winter supplies to affected populations. In **Haiti**, youth registration on the U-Report platform grew to 90,333 active users, with a 67 per cent participation rate, underscoring the vital role of youth engagement in humanitarian response.

Significant progress was made in 2024 in supporting governments in strengthening local and national systems for systematic adolescent engagement. With UNICEF's support, **Romania** became the first country in the world to adopt legislation on embedding child and adolescent participation into national and local processes. UNICEF is now working with the government on secondary legislation, including guidance on organizing child and youth consultations, preparing professionals to manage these consultations, and setting up reporting systems. In **Armenia**, UNICEF supported the government to develop a Law on Youth Policy aimed at strengthening mechanisms that encourage systematic participation of adolescents. In **Lao PDR**, UNICEF worked with the Ministry of Information and the Youth Union (an arm of government with 250,000 members across the country) to support youth with skills- and capacity-building, empowering them to achieve change on matters that affect them, including adolescent marriage and pregnancy, climate change and the environment. In **Colombia**, UNICEF supported technical capacity-building using the 'Semillas de Cambio' (Seeds of Change) toolkit, whereby 18 local governments strengthened their capacity to design and implement plans focused on adolescents; at national level, the toolkit was formally adopted by the government. In **Côte d'Ivoire**, UNICEF advanced the operationalization of the Youth Orientation Law and the government's Youth Programme, aimed at enhancing the participation, training, employment and entrepreneurship of adolescents and youth. In **El Salvador**, UNICEF partnered with the government in developing child protection policies that include adolescent participation, and worked with the Ministry of Education on a student participation policy. In **Indonesia**, UNICEF transitioned the Monitoring Information System to the Ministry of Women Empowerment and Child Protection, which systemically tracks young people's participation in decision-making processes.

In 2024, the Adolescent Kit⁵¹ reached an additional 350,000 adolescents in 15 countries, with over 4,000 facilitators, teachers and youth volunteers trained on its implementation. In **Sudan**, it was used in all 18 states to equip over 70,300 adolescent girls with the information and skills needed to become active partners in UNICEF's

U-Report is UNICEF's digital community for young people, by young people. Across more than 90 countries, U-Report empowers youth aged 13–24 to share ideas and opinions, find out about issues that affect them, and take action. In 2024, U-Report added 2 new platforms to reach a total of 105 platforms, and 4.4 million new registered users, reaching 37 million U-Reporters globally. Highlights included: results from an adolescent girls' rights poll launched at a high-level policy event with UNICEF's Executive Director and other senior leaders to amplify the five policy asks for girls globally; in response to the mpox outbreak, U-Report poll results provided insights about awareness, perception of risk, vaccination intentions, and preferred communication sources and channels to support effective humanitarian response strategies and actions; and young people accessing resources to support their mental health through a series of new global chatbots.

emergency response. In addition, the global Youth-led Action Initiative⁵² launched in 2023 grew to over 70 countries, accelerating the impact of young change-makers to positively transform themselves and their communities.

Under UNICEF's Adolescent Girls' Strategy (2022–2025), UNICEF reached over 15 million more girls, alongside boys, parents, front-line workers and community members. UNICEF scaled up or introduced new multisectoral programmes designed with, and for, adolescent girls in 63 countries, anchored across the education and skills, protection, economic empowerment, health and nutrition sectors. UNICEF also supported the second powerful cohort of the Global Girl Leaders Advisory Group,⁵³ comprised of adolescent girls and young women who serve in a leadership and advisory body to UNICEF under the Adolescent Girls' Programme Strategy.⁵⁴

UNICEF's global partnerships, including the Compact for Young People in Humanitarian Action and the PROSPECTS partnership, have leveraged the strengths of key actors such as the Dutch Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the International Labour Organization, the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees and the Global Refugee Youth Network.⁵⁵ These collaborations have enabled UNICEF to reach and engage more young people in forced displacement and marginal contexts. As a result, these young people have gained access to skills-building, advocacy platforms, community action and inclusion in national systems, including participation in the United Nations Economic and Social Council Youth Forum and Youth Action Day session at the Summit of the Future.



Mohamed Badel Majeed (left), displaced from Khartoum, attends class at a safe learning space in Kassala state, Sudan.

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Spotlight on the Global Education Thematic Fund 2024



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UNICEF works across 12 of the 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) to bring about positive change for children. The Global Education Thematic Fund makes vital contributions to SDG 4: Ensure inclusive and equitable quality education and promote lifelong learning opportunities for all.

1. UNICEF's Global Education Thematic Fund: Promoting every child's right to learn

Every child has the right to learn. Yet for far too many, that right remains unfulfilled. Poverty, environmental shocks, conflict, displacement, disability and discrimination continue to keep children out of school or stuck in classrooms without meaningful learning, or disrupt learning altogether. This is especially true for girls and other vulnerable children. In emergencies, education is often one of the first services disrupted and one of the last to recover.

UNICEF is working to change this – not only by delivering education services but by helping countries, especially low-income countries, to build stronger, more resilient education systems that provide inclusive learning for all children, in all contexts.

At the heart of this work is the Global Education Thematic Fund, UNICEF's most strategic tool for advancing quality education at scale. Powered by flexible, multi-year contributions, the Fund enables UNICEF to work with agility, respond to emergencies, support national reform, scale what works, and integrate education across health, protection and social services.

Investments to the Global Education Thematic Fund support a more inclusive, resilient and prosperous world for every child and have a transformative effect across multiple SDGs.

"Every child deserves the chance to learn, and every partner who contributes to thematic funding is helping make that possible. This fund is more than a financial tool, it is a shared commitment to equity, resilience and the power of education to transform lives."

Kitty van der Heijden, Deputy Executive Director, Partnerships, UNICEF

2. Financial results

Investment catalysing progress for generations

The progress made in education over recent decades – including 5 million more children enrolled in primary school – has been possible thanks to partners who choose to support inclusive, resilient and equitable education systems that unlock opportunity for generations.

In 2024, the Global Education Thematic Fund mobilized US\$17.5 million in flexible, catalytic funding from committed public and private partners. UNICEF extends sincere thanks to the Governments of Norway, Sweden, and Luxembourg, and private sector partners Chery Automobile, easyJet, ING España, Ahlström Collective Impact, Sandvik Coromant, Saxo and others who contributed to the Fund, including through National Committees. Every contribution to the Fund accelerates impact, helping deliver not just classrooms but futures full of potential.

Sector	Donor	Amount (US\$)
Public	Norway	4,678,581
	Sida – Sweden	3,399,709
	Luxembourg	715,647
	Swedish Committee for UNICEF	2,710,131
	Dutch Committee for UNICEF	1,105,540
	Japan Committee for UNICEF	878,493
	Spanish Committee for UNICEF	864,852
	UNICEF Country Office PSFR	800,000
	Finnish Committee for UNICEF	749,683
Private	Italian Committee for UNICEF – Foundation Onlus	458,837
	Norwegian Committee for UNICEF	222,036
	Korean Committee for UNICEF	177,855
	United States Fund for UNICEF	166,282
	German Committee for UNICEF	142,632
	United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF	121,554
	Hong Kong Committee for UNICEF	100,347
	Danish Foundation for UNICEF	72,995
	Luxembourg Committee for UNICEF	68,827
	French Committee for UNICEF	30,333
	Committee for UNICEF Switzerland and Liechtenstein	30,333
	Portuguese Committee for UNICEF	17,694
	Australian Committee for UNICEF Limited	10,040
Grand Total		17,522,401

Note: Numbers may not add up due to rounding. PSFR: Private sector fundraising.

¹ The thematic funding contributions relate to the Strategic Plan 2022–2025.



A group of children, dressed in their bright red and white uniforms, in Sri Lanka, run with laughter and excitement, their smiles radiating happiness.

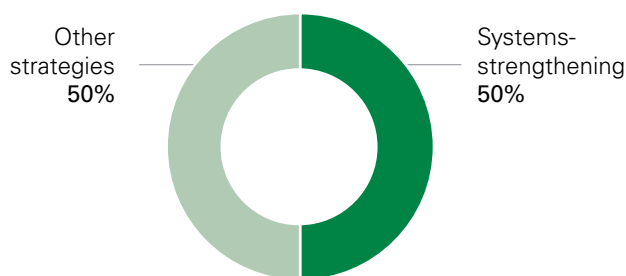
© UNICEF/UNI728212/InceptChange

Why flexible funding matters

What sets the Global Education Thematic Fund apart is not just where the money goes, but how it works. With flexible, multi-year funding invested over the four-year period of UNICEF's Strategic Plan (2022–2025), UNICEF can strengthen education systems to deliver progress towards achieving SDG 4 – quality education for all.

In 2024, UNICEF incurred US\$22.2 million in flexible thematic funding expense through the Education Thematic Fund. These investments advanced foundational learning, inclusive education, and the development of resilient, green and digitally enabled learning environments. Every flexible dollar helps bring the world closer to inclusive, quality education for every child.

UNICEF expense by programme strategy, 2024



In 2024, 50 per cent of Education thematic funding was spent on strengthening education systems.

Note: The category 'other' consists of strategies that enable systems-strengthening, including advocacy and communications; social and behaviour change; data and research; digital transformation; innovation; partnerships and engagement; and support to programme delivery.

A call to scale what works

Achieving SDG 4 is not a distant ambition. It is an urgent necessity. It requires accelerated investments in education systems, especially in low-income countries, that make inclusive, equitable and resilient education possible for every child.

The Global Education Thematic Fund is UNICEF's most strategic tool for driving that transformation. The Fund enables countries to go beyond short-term fixes and deliver long-term impact – improving foundational learning, investing in teachers, expanding digital access and ensuring schools can withstand conflict, environmental shocks and other crises.

We call on partners to help us scale what works.

Together, we can accelerate progress, close equity gaps and create a future where every child learns, leads and thrives – no matter where they live.



Transparency with Thematic Funding

UNICEF has a strong financial transparency record, including for thematic funding. We encourage UNICEF partners to the Global Education Thematic Fund to visit the Transparency Portal and access real-time information on spending in the countries receiving funds.

3. The footprint of the Global Education Thematic Fund

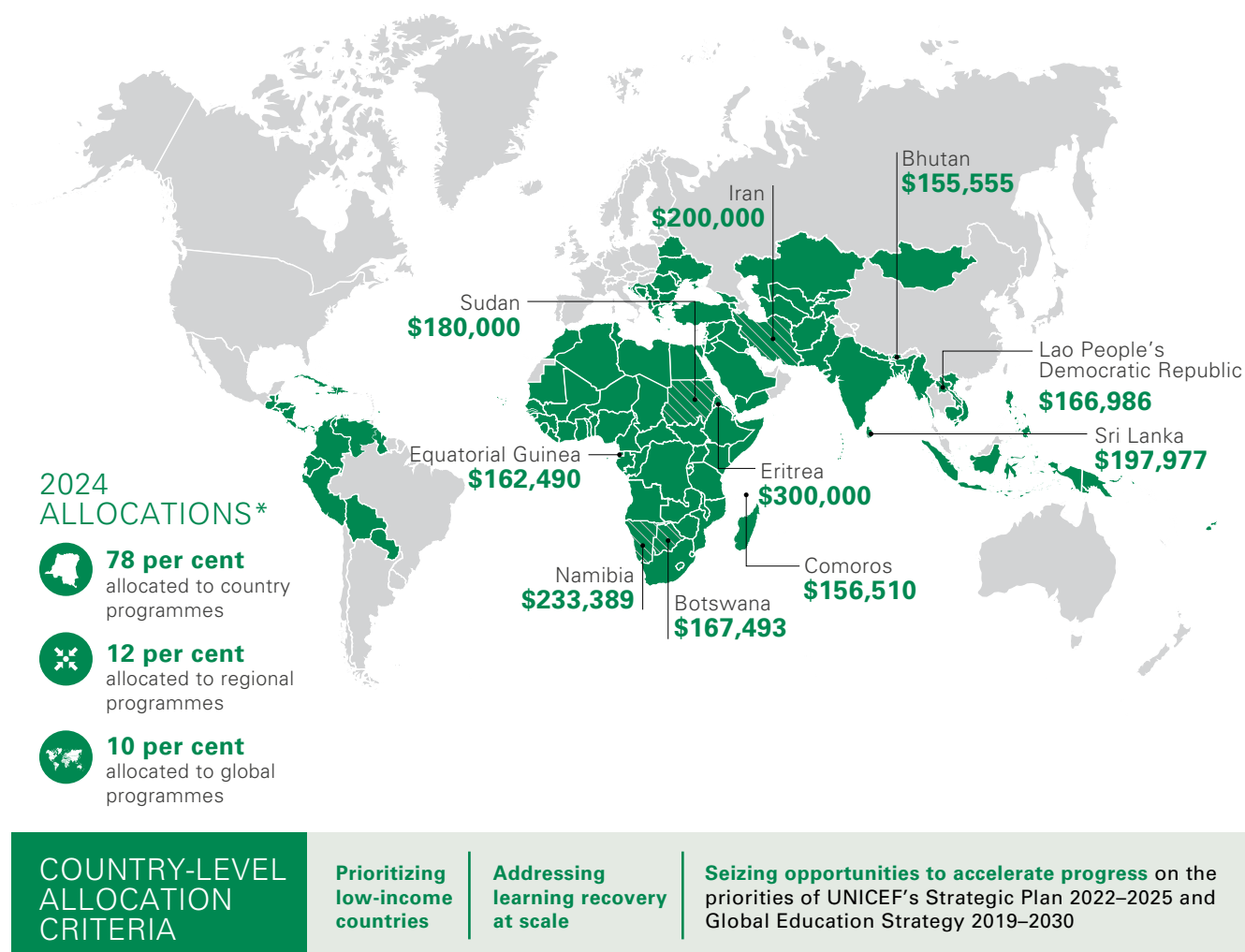
The reach of the Global Education Thematic Fund spans all seven UNICEF regions, delivering impact across three interconnected levels:

- At the **country level**: Investments help strengthen national systems, expand services and target support to children who are furthest behind.
- At the **regional level**: Investments build technical expertise, foster collaboration across borders, position policy and accelerate the adoption of promising practices.

- At the **global level**: Investments support UNICEF's technical and thought leadership in developing tools, guidance, data frameworks and innovations that help scale results for children everywhere.

Each level reinforces the others, enabling UNICEF to drive sustainable improvements in education with every investment.

THE Global Education Thematic Fund allocations around the world²



Note: This map is stylized and not to scale. It does not reflect a position by UNICEF on the legal status of any country or area or the delimitation of any frontiers.

² The map shows all countries that received allocations from the Global Education Thematic Fund between 2022 and 2024. The 10 highest allocations in 2024 are shown with full amounts.

4. From programmes to policy: A systems shift in education

The global education crisis is not just an issue of access; it is also an issue of equity, quality and resilience. UNICEF's response is rising to meet the scale of the need. Across regions and contexts, the Global Education Thematic Fund is advancing a transformation from fragmented interventions to strong education systems that uphold every child's right to learn, thrive and shape their future.

UNICEF's systems-strengthening model is anchored in workforce development, policy and legislative reform, social and behaviour change, data and evidence, infrastructure for service delivery and sustainable financing – and proven in delivering measurable and holistic results.

In 2024, flexible thematic funding played a catalytic role across UNICEF's global Education portfolio, both in development and humanitarian contexts, ensuring that investments across four pillars not only expand access but also improve learning outcomes and system resilience.

Below are some headline sector results for which thematic funding, as part of a broader portfolio of funding, was a key contributor.

Infrastructure for service delivery

Robust infrastructure is essential for effective education systems. Beyond buildings, it means safe, inclusive learning environments with reliable water and sanitation, digital connectivity, and access to quality learning materials. When infrastructure is robust and resilient, children can continue learning even during crises, and communities are better equipped to withstand disruption. UNICEF is helping countries build education systems that are not only functional but also resilient.

In 2024, the proportion of countries with resilient education systems grew to 40 per cent, from 32 per cent in 2023.

UNICEF supported adaptation of school infrastructure and introduced environmental education in 91 countries, up from 65 in 2023.

Flexible thematic funding made it possible to translate these global shifts into tangible results in numerous countries:

- In **Myanmar**, UNICEF's targeted support to the most marginalized crisis-affected children ensured more than **277,580 children and adolescents**, including nearly **470 children with disabilities**, can access and continue education through temporary learning centres established in camps for internally displaced persons and surrounding communities.
 - In the **State of Palestine**, UNICEF supported nearly **5,660 children in Gaza** to return to learning, through the delivery of educational activities in 12 safe temporary learning spaces.
 - In **Ukraine**, UNICEF established 12 youth spaces that have reached around **500,000 young people**. These spaces have fostered mental well-being, social inclusion and career readiness.
 - In **Eritrea**, UNICEF helped ensure uninterrupted learning for **6,500 children** by equipping 12 remote schools with solar panels, batteries and computers, enabling sustainable access to quality education.
 - In **Ecuador**, UNICEF and the Ministry of Education piloted an early warning system in 17 schools and trained **510 educators**. These actions led to improved emergency coordination and ensured timely support for more than **5,800 students**.
- These efforts show that with the right infrastructure, every child, no matter where they live, can stay connected to learning.



Samrawit Gebrihwot, 10-year-old student, who attends the UNICEF-supported FreKalsi Primary School, Tigray Region, Ethiopia. She shares "I love learning, but I also love to play with my friends, especially jumping rope."

© UNICEF/UNI707264/



Justine, 10, poses by the window of a classroom at Munoza Primary School in Walikale, North Kivu province, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, 2024.

© UNICEF/UNI767626/Benekire

Laws and policies

Strong education systems require laws, policies and budgets that guarantee every child's right to learning.

UNICEF works hand in hand with governments on national education sector plans and programmes and the pioneering of inclusive education policies.

In 2024, 73 per cent of countries where UNICEF has education programmes had implemented evidence-based education sector plans that address inequities and align with the SDGs, up from 65 per cent in 2023.

UNICEF supported 102 countries to advance inclusive education systems, with 58 per cent reporting an enabling environment, up from 55 per cent in 2023.

Thematic funding was pivotal in enabling context-sensitive programming at the country level:

- In **Indonesia**, UNICEF helped local governments develop tailored education programmes that prevented an estimated **176,000 children** from dropping out and helped **71,300 children** return to school.
- In **Algeria**, to reduce repetition rates (estimated at 20 per cent), UNICEF supported pedagogical remediation strategies targeting first-year middle school students. Training educators to interpret primary school evaluations and tailor responses to students at risk of repetition led to **an average increase in students' grades of five points**.
- In **Honduras**, to accelerate learning recovery, UNICEF and the government:
 - Developed and implemented a national plan to increase enrolment and reduce dropout rates, with over **160,000 more students** enrolled in comparison to the previous year.

- Leveraged resources to provide internet connectivity to more than **402,100 students** and over **22,100 teachers**.
- Developed digital learning initiatives benefiting over **47,200 students** in the country.

UNICEF's approach is clear: build strong systems, empower educators and remove barriers so that every child can access the education they deserve.

Workforce development

Teachers are at the heart of quality education. UNICEF works globally to ensure that educators receive high-quality, continuous professional development that is responsive to local needs. This not only improves learning outcomes but also makes education more inclusive and accessible, particularly for marginalized children and youth, including girls and children with disabilities.

Thematic funding helped advance quality teaching and the use of inclusive pedagogy:

- In the **Democratic Republic of the Congo**, UNICEF enhanced the skills and capacity of more than **1,840 teachers** in key aspects of curricular reform and distributed learning materials to more than **311,500 children**, laying the groundwork to improve the quality of learning and foundational skills, particularly in reading and mathematics, where national assessments showed concerning proficiency levels.
- In **India**, UNICEF supported inclusive education for **450,000 children** by developing a toolkit for infrastructure accessibility audits and training nearly **168,000 schoolteachers, educators for children with disabilities, and therapists**.

- In **Sri Lanka**, UNICEF's modelling of child-centred teaching strategies reached nearly **7,200 teachers** and **143,000 children**, strengthening foundational learning outcomes at scale.
- In **Bosnia and Herzegovina**, UNICEF supported the integration of assistive technology into higher education and teacher training by partnering with the University of Sarajevo. A dedicated module on assistive technology was added to the permanent inclusive education training programme.

Data, research and evidence for education solutions

Reliable data and strong evidence are essential to transform education systems and reach the children most often left behind. UNICEF supports governments to strengthen data systems, generate research and use evidence to drive smarter, more equitable education responses.

By identifying who is out of school or is not learning – and why – UNICEF helps countries design programmes that not only expand access but improve the quality and impact of learning.

Using thematic funding, UNICEF deepened its engagement on accountability tracking globally. The Foundational Learning Action Tracker (FLAT) expanded its data coverage to 123 low- and middle-income countries in 2024 (up from 120 in 2023). It generated 30 country scorecards, 7 regional briefs and 2 African snapshots, offering actionable insights that informed 5 national education policy discussions and were featured in 18 global and regional events. FLAT has been a vital accountability tool, helping to catalyse government awareness and drive action on foundational learning. In 2024, the Country Action Tracker for Children – Early Childhood Education (CATCH-ECE) was successfully piloted within the FLAT framework, engaging 89 countries in the process.

Technical support with thematic funding at country level helped governments turn data into action:

- In **Guinea Bissau**, UNICEF-supported school mapping uncovered nearly 3,000 non-active staff positions. This efficiency measure freed up **US\$3.5 million** of government funds, enabling the hiring of over **4,000 contract teachers** and expanding access to learning for thousands of children.
- In **Bangladesh**, UNICEF helped establish and strengthen quality assurance in pre-primary education delivered in government primary schools across the country. The monitoring and oversight skills of **3,100 field officers** and **180 government officials** were enhanced through guidance and training to ensure adherence to standards, and **3,400 teachers** gained specialized knowledge and skills to implement pre-primary education.

- In **Iran**, UNICEF's assessments informed targeted support for Afghan refugee families and host communities. The result:
 - **2,500 children** gained learning opportunities.
 - **17,000 children** benefited from improved learning environments.
 - **2,400 parents** and **150 teachers** and education officials received capacity-strengthening support.

Evidence is not just collected; it is used. With flexible funding, UNICEF helps governments translate data into action, turning insights into impact for millions of children, and stronger accountability for progress.

Results that last

In 2024, flexible thematic funding played a catalytic role in UNICEF's strategic education investments, delivering measurable, system-level progress; ensuring more children, including those in crisis contexts, could access quality learning and build brighter futures; and contributing to meaningful progress at scale:

- **26 million out-of-school children and adolescents** gained access to education, including **9 million in humanitarian settings** and **3.7 million children** on the move.
- Learning materials reached **17.5 million children**, 27 per cent in crisis-affected areas.

These numbers reflect more than just scale; they represent lives transformed, rights fulfilled, and systems strengthened to deliver education that lasts.



Scan the QR code or click on the image to read UNICEF's Data Companion and Scorecard for more information on progress against SDG and Strategic Plan targets. Thematic Funding as part of UNICEF's overall funding portfolio contributes to this progress.

5. Impact story

Building foundations: Transforming early learning in the Dominican Republic

In the Dominican Republic, a quiet revolution in education is reshaping the earliest school years. For too long, children struggled with low learning outcomes in reading, writing and mathematics, not because they lacked potential but because the system lacked the tools to support them. Inadequate teaching methods in the early grades were holding students back from acquiring the foundational skills they need to learn and thrive.

Now, that is beginning to change. With the support of the Global Education Thematic Fund, UNICEF and the Ministry of Education have launched a national transformation. The Building the Foundations for Learning (CON BASE) programme is equipping teachers with the training, resources and methodologies they need to help children build strong early literacy and numeracy skills. What began as a pilot has now reached every corner of the country – a full national scale-up.

The government has backed this ambition with a three-year commitment of US\$10 million. Flexible thematic funding was the catalyst. It enabled UNICEF to recruit technical experts, co-design the programme, develop teaching materials and support the pilot phase, laying the groundwork for the government to expand and institutionalize the programme nationwide. Today, 16,000 teachers are trained each year, supporting more than 450,000 students in the first three grades of primary school.

Change is already visible in the classroom. Data from a national learning assessment in 2024 show sharp gains, particularly among the children struggling the most. In Spanish language, the proportion of students in the lowest-performing group achieving satisfactory results in writing jumped from 17 per cent to 50 per cent. In mathematics, the proportion increased from 47 per cent to 65 per cent in basic competencies such as solving calculations and counting.



This progress is not just a testament to the programme's quality; it is a powerful reminder of what is possible when systems are strengthened from the inside out. UNICEF is now supporting the full transfer of CON BASE to government management, ensuring that gains are not just preserved but sustained.

The Dominican Republic's commitment to foundational learning is part of a global effort. Around the world, UNICEF is working to help countries transform early education, with literacy and numeracy as the bedrock of lifelong learning.

This is the impact of the Global Education Thematic Fund. Your support ensures not just access to learning but quality learning that lasts, reaching children who have been left behind and giving them the tools to succeed.

"Literacy is the most important tool for children. It is their right – and the foundation for a country's development and participation in the global economy."

– Carlos Carrera, UNICEF Representative, Dominican Republic

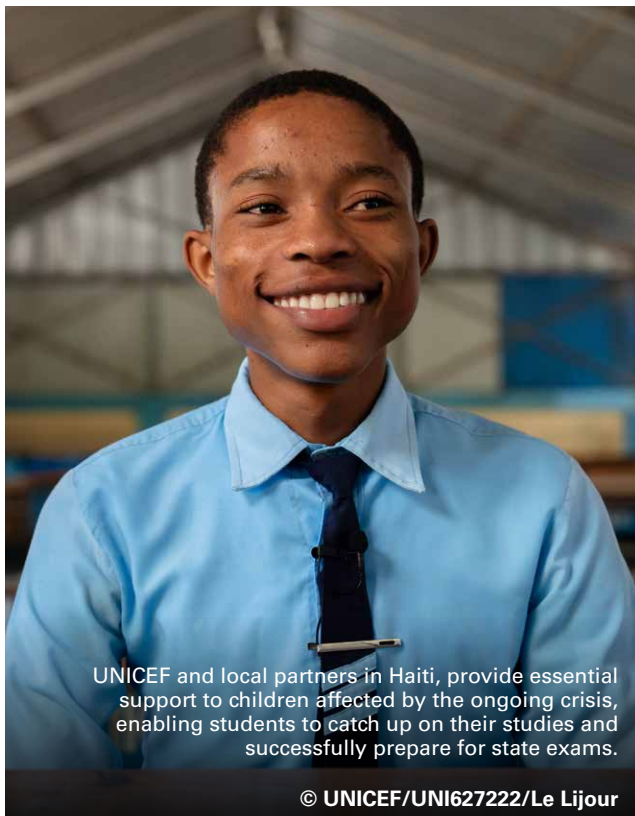
6. Hearing from our donors and partners

Norway and UNICEF: Advancing quality education through flexible investment

In 2024, Norway reaffirmed its position as UNICEF's leading public sector partner for the Global Education Thematic Fund, delivering flexible, innovative support to advance inclusive, quality education, especially in fragile contexts. By investing in UNICEF's mandate through strategic thematic funding, Norway enables system-wide change that reaches the most marginalized children.

Norway's multi-year contributions have been catalytic in addressing pandemic-related learning losses, expanding access for out-of-school children and strengthening equitable education systems. This approach – prioritizing national capacity-building and scalable solutions – exemplifies the power of thematic funding to drive cross-sectoral impact across education, child protection, health and gender equality.

As UNICEF advances its 2022–2025 Strategic Plan, its partnership with Norway stands as a model for achieving lasting gains in education access, retention and learning – demonstrating how schools can become transformative spaces of inclusion, safety and opportunity.



UNICEF and local partners in Haiti, provide essential support to children affected by the ongoing crisis, enabling students to catch up on their studies and successfully prepare for state exams.

© UNICEF/UNI627222/Le Lijour

Chery Automobile: Powering every child's learning journey



In 2024, Chery Automobile, a leading global automotive manufacturer, was the most significant private sector contributor to UNICEF's Global Education Thematic Fund. This landmark partnership reflects Chery's commitment to supporting children's right to quality education and contributing to a more inclusive, equitable future.

Chery's commitment to supporting UNICEF's mission – ensuring every child, everywhere, has access to learning opportunities that unlock their full potential – aligns closely with its corporate social responsibility vision: to promote social progress and create a better way of life for all.

Transforming education through strategic support

Chery's catalytic investment in UNICEF's Global Education Thematic Fund is strengthening education systems to deliver transformative change for the most vulnerable children. By supporting girls' education in science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM), teacher training and inclusive learning environments, this flexible funding helps break down barriers to quality primary and secondary education while pioneering innovative approaches to reach children in emergencies.

By investing in systemic solutions, Chery's partnership is helping drive progress towards SDG 4: quality education for all.

A partnership with global impact

Chery's support empowers UNICEF to reach millions of out-of-school children, strengthen education systems and promote inclusive, lifelong learning. This collaboration showcases how private sector leadership can accelerate progress and create a lasting impact for children worldwide.

UNICEF extends its sincere gratitude to Chery Automobile for its visionary support and shared commitment to ensuring quality education for every child.



Grade 7 students receive their first-ever year-end assessment cards at a UNICEF-supported learning centre in the Rohingya refugee camps in Cox's Bazar, Bangladesh, May 2024.

© UNICEF/UNI578413

Looking forward

Education is every child's right. High-quality, inclusive and relevant education is the foundation that provides children and young people with the skills needed to participate and thrive in a dynamic and transforming economy. Education empowers, gives young people the chance to develop a livelihood, equips them with an understanding of their rights and obligations, and helps lift them out of poverty and keep them safe from harm. Education helps countries create cohesion among populations, generates a skilled workforce to build industry, and advances equitable economic, social and sustainable development.

Amid the global learning crisis lies an unprecedented opportunity: the chance for stakeholders to identify and deliver sustainable solutions that address barriers and core systemic failures that are derailing learning where learning is denied, learning is not progressing, and learning is interrupted. To ensure that every child and young person is in school and learning, sustainable solutions must mitigate the impact of learning disruptions such as conflict, climate hazards and other crises that push children out of the learning system, some never to return.

UNICEF's solutions will be framed across three transitions of the learning journey to enable developmentally tailored learning opportunities from early childhood into young adulthood: Learning Early by age 5; Learning the Basics by age 10; and Learning for Life and Work by age 18. Notably, UNICEF will continue to work with governments and partners to mobilize sustained action towards universalization of early learning support for the youngest learners, driven by compelling evidence emphasizing the imperative to invest in the foundational years of the first and second 1,000 days⁵⁶ as a cornerstone of human capital development, equity and lifelong learning.

Based on efforts and research around improving foundational learning, UNICEF developed five principles for effective scaling with quality, offering guidance for governments and their partners looking at different elements of scaling maturity: (1) effective scaling is about more than numbers; (2) it needs clear strategic goals; (3) it requires school/system-level considerations and requirements; (4) it needs systemic strategic planning; and (5) it is iterative. This framework will continue to be applied to scale up foundational learning interventions globally.

The 2024 evaluation of UNICEF's efforts to reduce the number of out of school children⁵⁷ underscores the transformative potential of multiple and flexible pathways (MFPs) to provide equitable learning opportunities. Key findings reveal that MFPs have successfully expanded access for vulnerable groups – girls, refugees and over-aged learners – through approaches such as accelerated education and community-based learning centres. MFPs facilitate re-entry into formal education and equip young people with transferable skills for work. However, the persistent challenges of limited scalability, inconsistent data, and low demand among communities and authorities hinder broader impact. Lessons learned highlight the importance of strategic alignment with national priorities, the potential of cross-sectoral partnerships to boost

enrolment, and the power of community engagement to leverage local expertise. Future programming will prioritize scale and sustainability through tailored guidance for all education levels, as well as enhanced data systems to track OOSC effectively. UNICEF will build on years of collaboration with partners such as Educate A Child and foster robust partnerships with governments and communities to drive systemic change for millions of OOSC worldwide.

To mitigate learning disruptions and enable equitable access to education, especially in remote, conflict-affected and climate-impacted regions, UNICEF will focus on resilient infrastructure and safe and supportive school environments, particularly for girls and for learners with disabilities. While significant progress has been made, lessons learned confirm that inclusion at scale requires systemic approaches embedded in national education systems and strategies. UNICEF's efforts will continue to focus on systemic progress, cross-sectoral coordination, and sustainable financing to ensure long-term impact. To accelerate learning recovery and build resilient education systems, UNICEF will scale up school-based mental health and psychosocial support as a core component of inclusive, quality education, with age-appropriate MHPSS embedded across all levels of education.

As part of systems-strengthening and improving learning outcomes, teachers, their development and well-being will be an explicit focus of future interventions. UNICEF will continue to make smarter, evidence-based investments that prioritize recruitment, training, retention and development of qualified teachers. This means not only improving professional development models but also ensuring teachers have the resources and support they need to thrive. While solving the global learning and skills crisis hinges on having well-trained and supported teachers, appropriate integration of technology into teaching will amplify teachers' impact and will be a game-changer to reach the most marginalized children.

UNICEF's newly launched Digital Education Strategy (2025–2030) will leverage digital innovation to drive quality learning and enable equity in access to learning and outcomes at scale. Guided by this vision, UNICEF will continue its mission to accelerate the digital transformation of education systems worldwide. This includes setting global standards for safe, inclusive and impactful education technology through the launch of the EdTech for Good Framework,⁵⁸ and by the establishment of the Learning Cabinet,⁵⁹ an online platform of solutions vetted through that framework. Developed with support from partners, including the Ministry for Foreign Affairs of Finland and the Asian Development Bank, these tools help decision makers identify fit-for-purpose, effective solutions.

To enable the delivery of evidence-based learning and skills solutions, UNICEF will continue to draw attention to worsening underinvestment in education and inequities in public education financing. UNICEF will advocate for the targeting of resources towards the poorest and most

marginalized children, and investments that promote learning outcomes through cost-effective and proven solutions.

With growing educational needs in emergencies, UNICEF will continue to advocate for education as a front-line priority in humanitarian responses to support children to return to learning with schools that offer safe places where their holistic needs are met. UNICEF will also continue to prioritize resilient education systems that can withstand increasing crises, engaging with governments to mainstream education in emergencies into national education sector plans.

Lessons from multisectoral collaboration demonstrate the value of integrated approaches. With its dual humanitarian–development mandate and whole-of-child approach, UNICEF will sustain its commitment to collaborate across the humanitarian, development and peace sectors while innovating to reach the most marginalized children. Through inclusive approaches, localized responses and systems-strengthening, UNICEF will continue working to ensure that every child and young person, including those affected by crisis, realizes their right to quality education.



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A girl attends class at the St. Luke's Methodist Primary School in Belize City, Belize. June 2024.

Endnotes

- 1 See <www.unesco.org/en/sdg4scorecard-dashboard>.
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Financial Annexⁱ

Glossary of key terms

Income, revenue and contributions received

- **Income:** Income includes contributions received in a given year from public sector partners (governments, including the European Commission, inter-organizational arrangements, global programme partnerships, and international financial institutions) and revenue from private sector partners. UNICEF uses income to prepare the financial framework, which forms part of the UNICEF Strategic Plan. Income is not part of the audited UNICEF financial statements.
- **Revenue:** UNICEF recognizes revenue for the full contribution agreement value when the partner agreement is signed in line with requirements of the International Public Sector Accounting Standards (IPSAS). This includes multi-year contribution agreements reflecting the full commitment of our partners for current and future years.
- **Contributions received:** Cash and contributions in kind received from resource partners within a calendar year.

Expenses and expenditures

- **Expenses** are recorded according to the International IPSAS and are accrual based. These are used for official financial reporting.
- **Expenditures** are recorded on a modified cash basis. They are used for budget reporting as they are aligned with cash disbursements and goods receipts (the way budgets are consumed).

Financial overview

Resources by type of funding

UNICEF has several funding modalities that work together to contribute to lasting impact; these include core and other resources, which include softly earmarked thematic funds, as well as tightly earmarked funds.

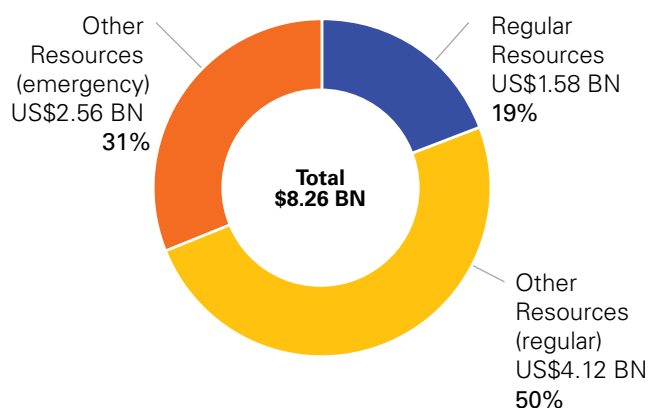
- Core Resources (RR) – contributions without restrictions within the framework of the Strategic Plan, to be used flexibly for children wherever and whenever the need is greatest.
- Other Resources Regular (ORR) – contributions that are earmarked by UNICEF partners for development programming. These can include flexible thematic funding at global, regional and country level. They can also be further earmarked for specific programmes or projects.
- Other Resources Emergency (ORE) – contributions that are earmarked by UNICEF partners for humanitarian programming. These can include flexible thematic funding for global, regional or further earmarked for specific emergency responses.

In a challenging economic climate, UNICEF's total income reached US\$8.26 billion in 2024, a 7 per cent or \$657 million decrease compared to 2023. These resources entrusted to UNICEF represent a spectrum, from funding earmarked to specific programmes to flexible funds given without any restriction to address the most pressing needs of children and to invest strategically in programming for scale, sustainability and resilience. The contributions from the public sector decreased by \$483 million compared to 2023, while private sector contributions decreased by \$221 million.

In 2024, Core Resources (RR) – UNICEF's most flexible funding – increased to 19 per cent of total income, from 18 per cent in 2023, to a total of \$1.58 billion.

The Funding Compact commitment of member states to increase core funding as share of the overall public sector and member states income fell short of the 30 per cent target in 2024. UNICEF is continuing to encourage partners to increase RR contributions as part of a broader portfolio approach across all funding types, ensuring the organization's presence globally and its ability to bring about systemic change to meet the needs of every child, everywhere.

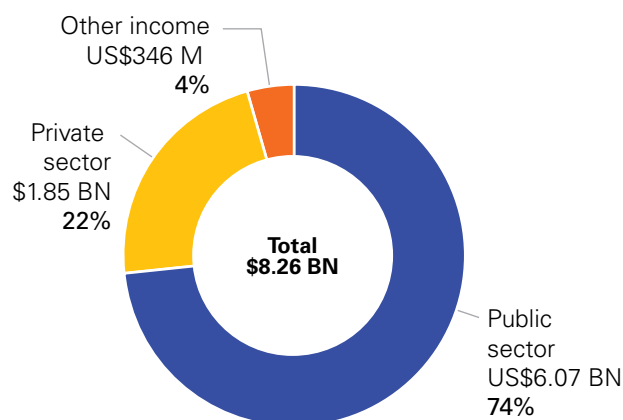
FIGURE A1: Income by type of funding, 2024



Resources by type of resource partner

In 2024, public sector income reached a \$6.07 billion, and made up 74 per cent of UNICEF's total income. Private sector income amounted to \$1.85 billion in 2024, which was 22 per cent of UNICEF's total income. Other income – including income from interest, procurement services and other sources – amounted to \$346 million or 4 per cent of UNICEF's total income.

FIGURE A2: Income by type of resource partner, 2024



Thematic funding

Thematic funds are softly earmarked pooled funds categorized as Other Resources (OR) and designed to support the achievement of results at country, regional and global levels. For partners, contributing to UNICEF's thematic funding pools enables them to champion the principles of good multilateral resource partnerships. Thematic funds deliver a higher return on investment for results for children, as their lower indirect cost recovery allows a greater share of funding to be directed toward programming, while also benefiting from transactional efficiencies compared to more tightly earmarked contributions. Thematic funding contributions continued to decline in 2024, from a record high of \$1.20 billion in 2022 (primarily driven by private sector funding for the Ukraine crisis) to \$475 million in 2023, down to \$361 million in 2024, constituting only 5 per cent of total OR. Thematic funding as a proportion of total OR from member states specifically decreased from 8 per cent in 2022 to 4 per cent in 2024, below the Funding Compact target of 15 per cent by 2027.

Private sector contributions – representing 58 per cent (\$211 million) of total thematic funding in 2024 – came from National Committees, 35 country offices and additional individual donors, including through online donations. Public sector contributions were provided by 20 governments and accounted for 42 per cent of thematic funding contributions in 2024 (\$150 million).

Apart from the spike in contributions in 2021 and 2022, largely from humanitarian private sector giving, the average level of thematic funding over the past decade has never reached more than 10 per cent of total OR contributions. UNICEF encourages partners to channel more contributions through these softly earmarked funds to allow maximum flexibility at the global, country and regional levels to strengthen results for children.

FIGURE A3: Contributions received by type of funding, 2024: Thematic vs non-thematic

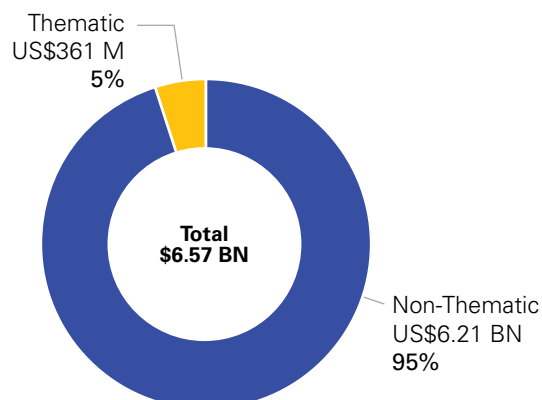


FIGURE A4: Thematic contributions received by resource partner, 2024: Public vs private

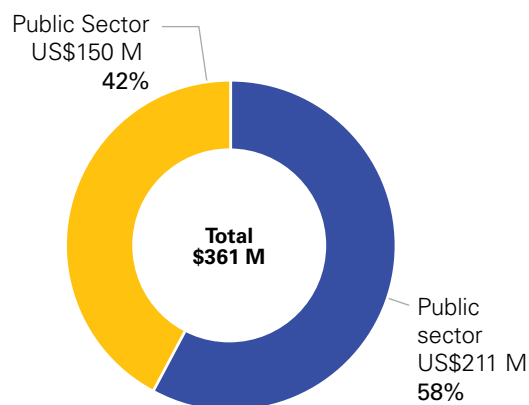
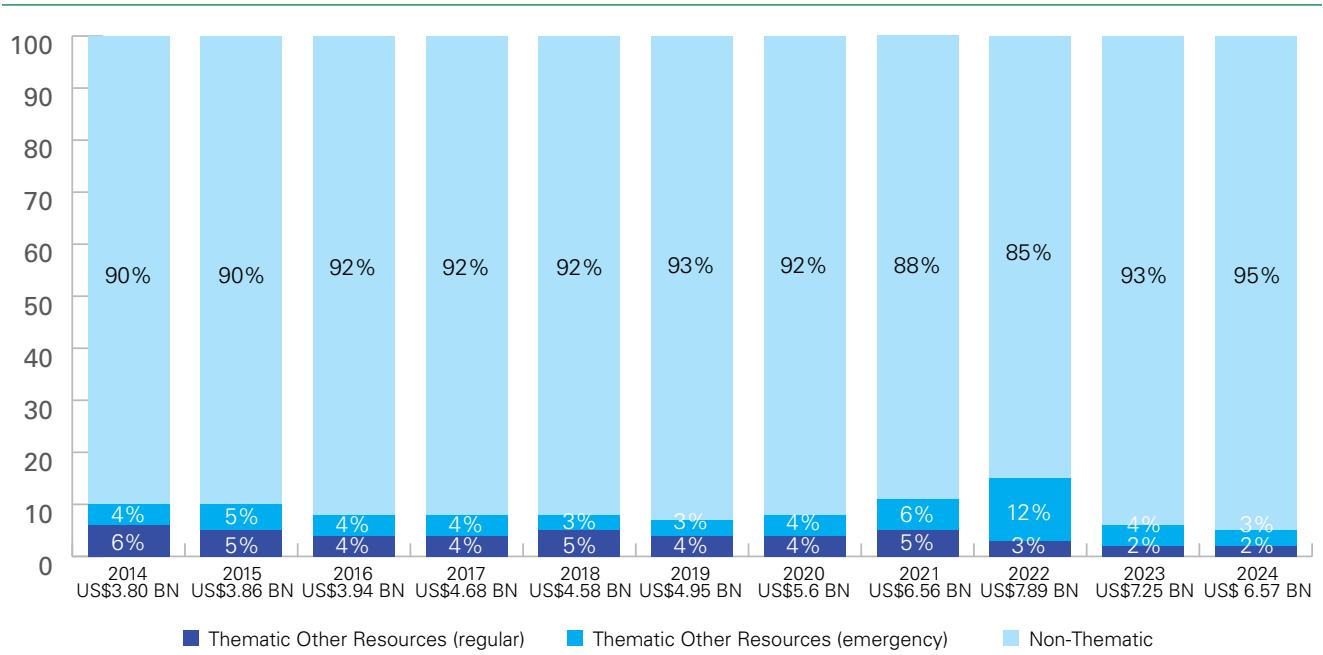
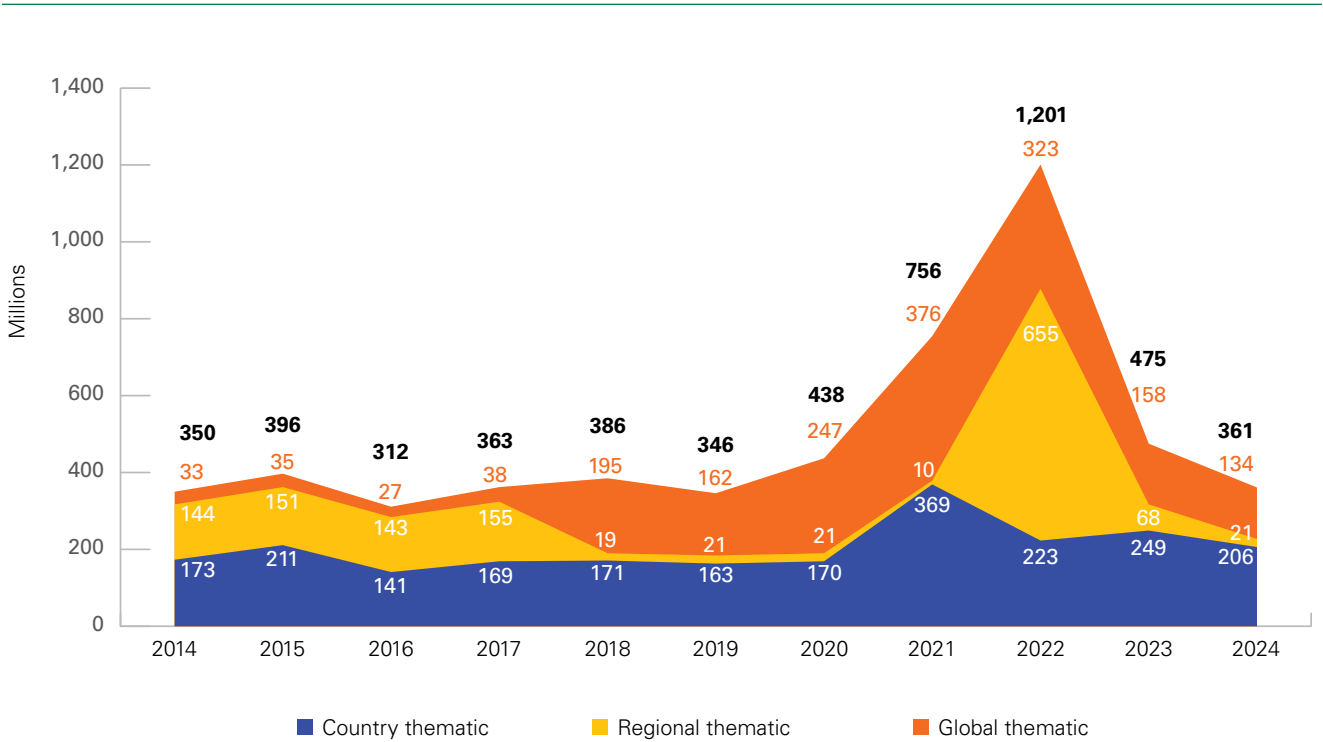


FIGURE A5: OR contributions received by type of funding, 2014-2024: Thematic vs non-thematic



In 2024, 57 per cent (\$206 million) of thematic funding was received through country-level pools, and 37 per cent (\$134 million) through global thematic funding and 6 per cent (\$21 million) through regional thematic funding.

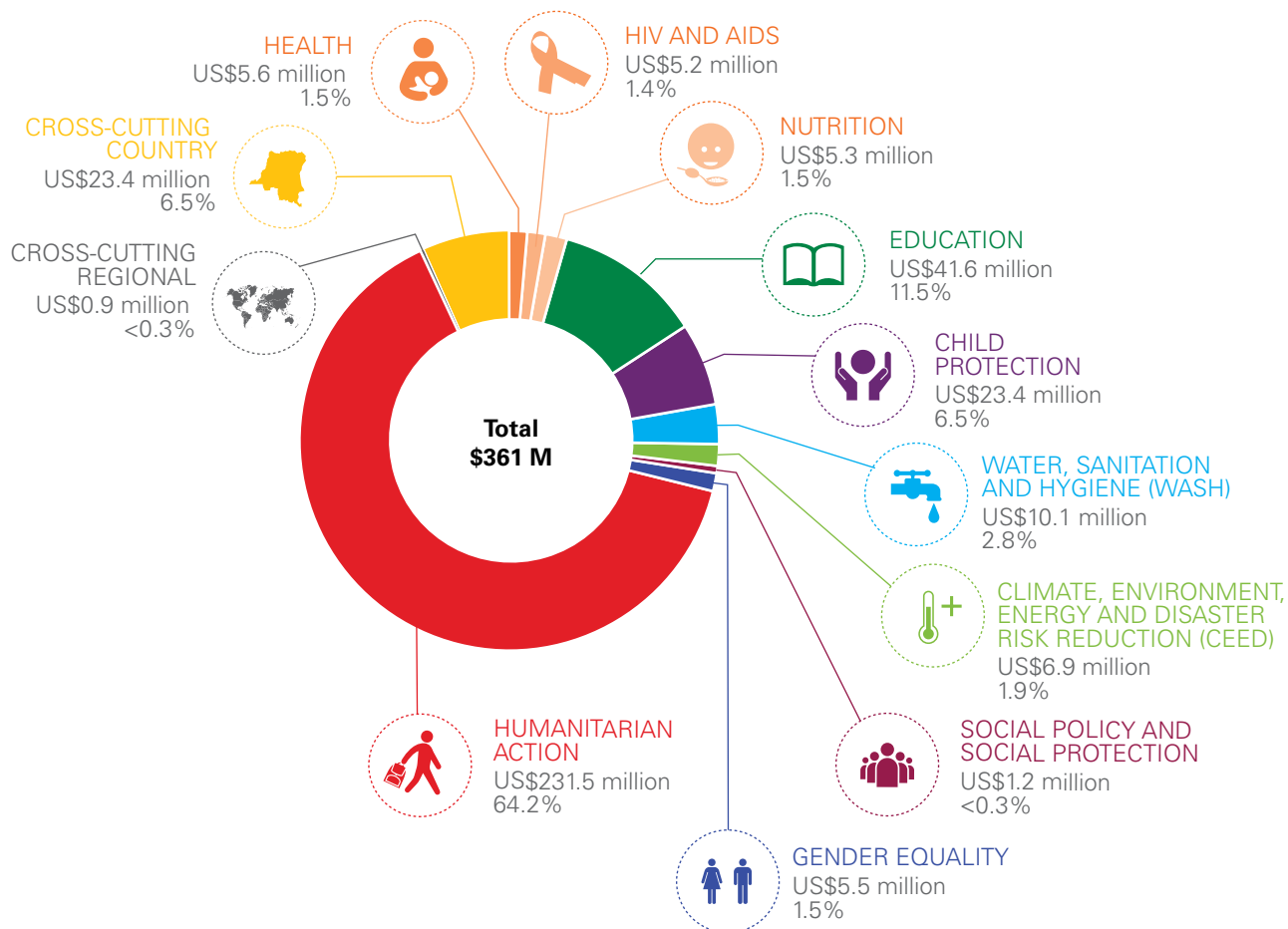
FIGURE A6: Thematic funding contributions received by type, 2014-2024



In 2024, the greatest amount of thematic funding received – 64 per cent – was for UNICEF’s humanitarian response. The increasing trend towards tightly earmarked resources

in development programming erodes the sustainability and predictability UNICEF needs to contribute to long-term impact for children in line with the SDGs.

FIGURE A7: Thematic contributions by funding pool, 2024



Donor Recognition

UNICEF programmes are funded entirely through the voluntary support of millions of people around the world and our partners in government, civil society and the private sector. Voluntary contributions enable UNICEF to deliver on its mandate to protect children’s rights, help meet their basic needs and expand their opportunities to reach their full potential. We take this opportunity to thank all our partners who contributed so generously in 2024 to our work for children around the world.

UNICEF would like to convey special appreciation to partners that have provided thematic contributions. This support enables UNICEF to respond effectively by strengthening systems across priority areas of work and promotes sustainability to achieve the greatest impact for children.

UNICEF’s Strategic Plan 2022-2025 includes the goal of doubling thematic funding as a share of all Other Resources. UNICEF is calling for member states to fulfill their Funding Compact commitment, and for all donors to increase flexible funding as a proportion of their overall portfolio of giving to UNICEF.

In 2024, the top 10 thematic funding resource partners contributed \$240 million, or 67 per cent of the total thematic contributions to UNICEF (see Figure 1). These partners provided 67 per cent of the total thematic funding for UNICEF’s non-humanitarian thematic pools, and 66 per cent of the total humanitarian thematic funding. The top three thematic funding partners in 2024 were Sweden, Denmark and the United States Fund for UNICEF. UNICEF would like to convey its sincere thanks to these partners for their ongoing and steadfast commitment to providing

flexible support to the organization. These three partners alone contributed 33 per cent, or \$119 million, of UNICEF's total thematic funding in 2024.

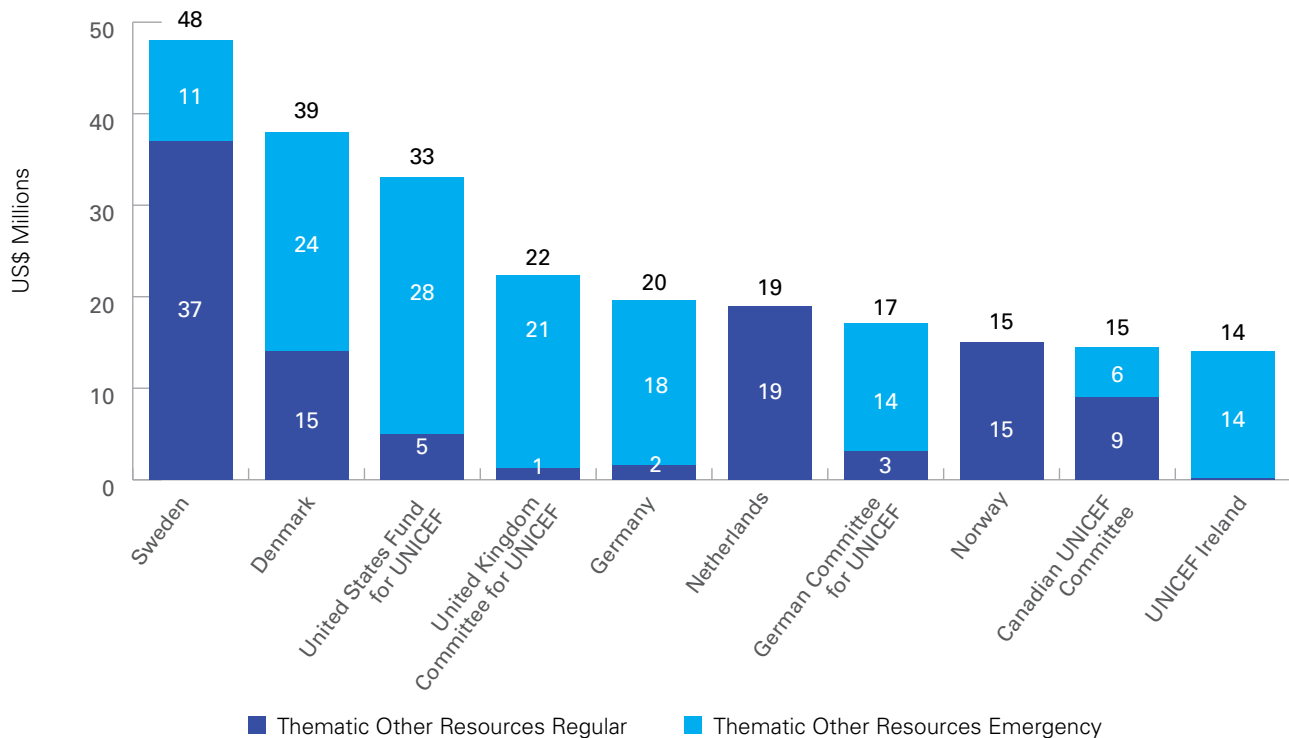
UNICEF would also like to recognize partners who have supported the new thematic modality of Country Programme funding for the UNICEF Strategic Plan 2022-2025. The Country Programme Document (CPD) thematic window, or flexible country window, allows maximum flexibility for UNICEF country offices to address challenges holistically, and supports an integrated approach, funding areas of work that may not be covered under other thematic grants or earmarked funding.

UNICEF is especially grateful to Sweden, a strong advocate and supporter of this modality. In 2024, Sweden remained by far the largest partner for CPD thematic funds, contributing \$10 million (41 % of total contributions to this modality in 2024) to support Country Programmes

in Bangladesh, the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Uganda. Sweden's contributions to CPD thematic funds since the outset of the current Strategic Plan up until 2024 amount to \$48 million (69% of total contributions to this modality).

In addition, UNICEF would like to recognize its private sector partners that are increasingly supporting the flexible country window. In 2024, the CPD thematic window received contributions from ten National Committees, which, together, contributed nearly \$13 million: the Canadian UNICEF Committee, the Committee for UNICEF Switzerland, the United States Fund for UNICEF, the German Committee for UNICEF, the Spanish Committee for UNICEF, the United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF, the Portuguese Committee for UNICEF, the Polish National Committee for UNICEF, French Committee for UNICEF and the Norwegian Committee for UNICEF.

FIGURE A8: Top 10 Resource Partners to Thematic Funding Pools, 2024, by Contributions Received



*Excluding UNICEF Country Office Private Sector Fundraising

Financial Information by Goal Area and/or sectorⁱⁱ

Goal Area 2: Learning and skills acquisition

In 2023, UNICEF received a total of \$819 million in OR for Goal Area 2, of which development contributions (ORR) were the vast majority, making up 90 per cent of total contributions. Public sector partners contributed the largest share of overall funding (80 per cent) while private sector partners contributed 20 per cent.

FIGURE A9: Goal Area 2 - OR contributions received by fund type, 2024

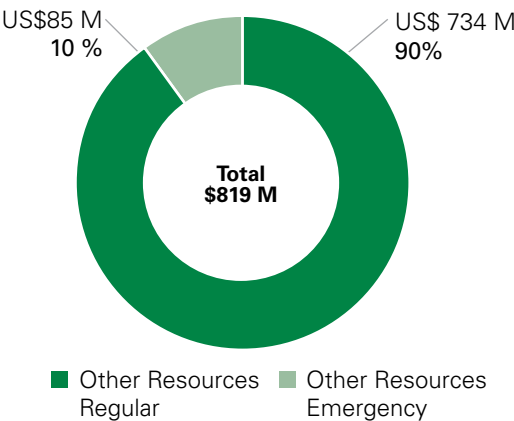
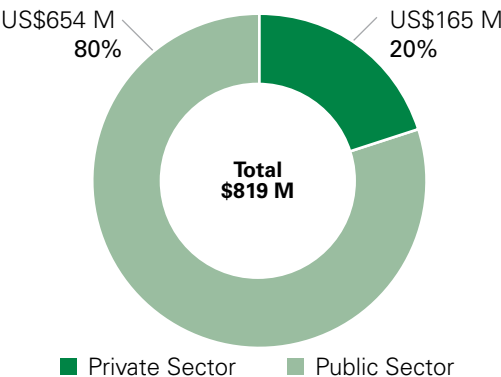


FIGURE A10: Goal Area 2 - OR contributions received by resource partner, 2024



Goal Area 2 received a total of \$42 million in thematic contributions in 2024, or 5 per cent of total OR contributions. Proportionally, this is consistent with 2022 and 2023, but remains significantly below the levels attained during the period of the previous Strategic Plan, 2018-2021, during which thematic contributions oscillated between 11 and 14 per cent of OR for the Goal Area. This poses a risk to the organization's ability to ensure predictable and timely funding to respond to emerging education priorities and under-resourced programmes.

FIGURE A11: Goal Area 2 - OR contributions received by type of funding, 2015–2024: Thematic vs non-thematic

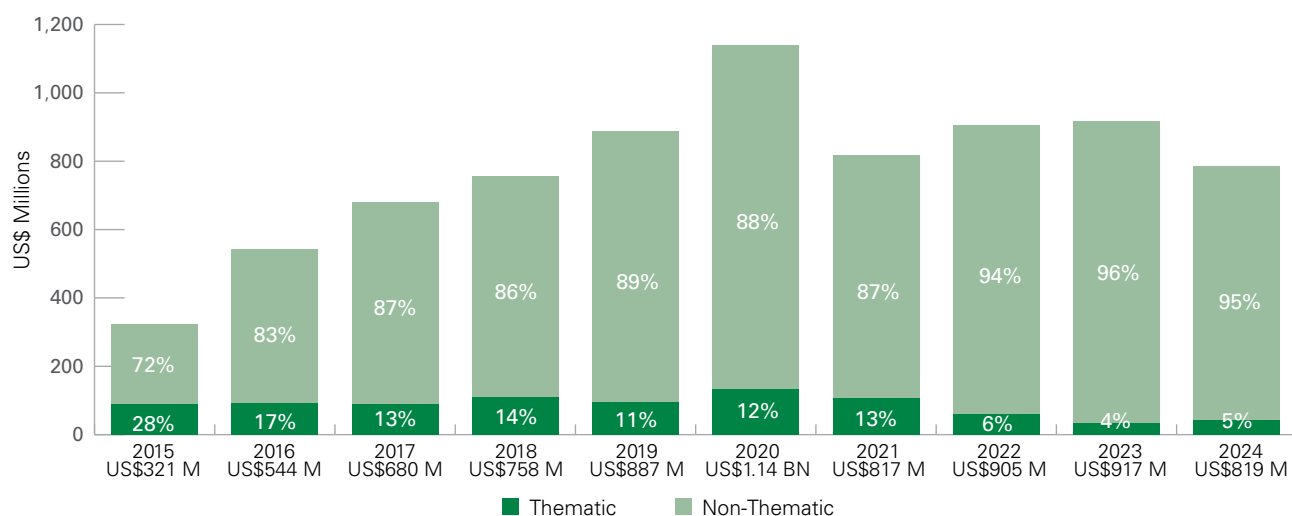


Table A1: Top 20 Resource Partners to Goal Area 2 by Total Contributions in US\$

Rank	Resource Partner	Contributions Received, 2024
1	Global Partnership for Education	219,975,399
2	European Commission	69,729,852
3	Germany	60,928,777
4	Education Cannot Wait Fund	53,182,512
5	United Kingdom	37,261,414
6	World Bank - Washington D.C.	31,956,777
7	UN Multi Partner Trust Fund	26,445,565
8	United States Fund for UNICEF	24,970,919
9	Committee for UNICEF Switzerland	21,096,653
10	Norway	20,267,788
11	Republic of Korea (the)	17,844,161
12	Canadian UNICEF Committee	17,492,546
13	France	14,499,693
14	Swedish Committee for UNICEF	12,801,610
15	Canada	12,741,780
16	German Committee for UNICEF	11,839,408
17	Danish Committee for UNICEF	10,816,792
18	United Kingdom Committee for UNICEF	10,583,861
19	Finland	10,538,876
20	Denmark	10,171,462

TABLE A2: Top 20 Contributions by Grant to Goal Area 2, 2024, in US\$

Rank	Grant Description	Resource Partner	Contributions Received, 2024
1	Afghanistan: To support continuity and build resilience for safe spaces of learn	Global Partnership for Education	44,291,795
2	GPE: System transformation grant allocation	Global Partnership for Education	29,790,341
3	Syria: Support to No Lost Generation (NLG) Initiative for children of Syria	KfW - Germany	24,543,594
4	Lebanon: Support to the Lebanese education sector, TREF SY 24/25	KfW - Germany	21,056,076
5	Rwanda: System Transformation Grant	Global Partnership for Education	19,281,012
6	Yemen: Restoring Education and Learning Project	World Bank	18,915,520
7	Giga Geneva Center - HW - Office of Global Innovation	Committee for UNICEF Switzerland	16,666,667
8	Uzbekistan: Window A. Empowering Education by Leveraging ICT and Digital	UN Multi Partner Trust Fund	16,207,289
9	Sierra Leone: GPE Multiplier grant 2023	Global Partnership for Education	15,748,878
10	BiquWeta programme: Unlocking the potential of conflict affected youth-Mastercard	Canadian UNICEF Committee	14,985,000
11	ECW: Education Cannot Wait Funds for UNICEF Chad	Education Cannot Wait Fund	11,867,639
12	Girls Initiative to Revitalize Learning and Success Fund (GIRLS Fund)-PD	United States Fund for UNICEF	11,557,154
13	Syria: provide continued education support in earthquake-affected areas in Syria	Global Partnership for Education	11,235,000
14	Türkiye - Education - EUR 29.7M	European Commission/EC	10,474,176
15	Ethiopia: GPE: Girls' Education Accelerator grant allocation (GEA)	Global Partnership for Education	9,822,529
16	Haiti: Soutenir l'accès à une éducation de qualité dans la péninsule sud d'Haïti	UN Multi Partner Trust Fund	9,676,023
17	Myanmar: Reprogramming ESPIG to provide education to marginalized vulnerable children	Global Partnership for Education	9,019,212
18	Zimbabwe: System Transformation Grant (STG)	Global Partnership for Education	8,638,483
19	Democratic Republic of the Congo: DRC GPE Funding	Agence Francaise de Developpement	8,604,749
20	Burundi: School construction, infrastructural equipment, and development of inclusive education in Burundi	Burundi	7,323,010

Contributions received from Burundi include \$7.3 million related to the Donors.

Expenses for Goal Area 2 totalled \$1.62 billion during 2024 across its two Result Areas. Of this, \$387 million (24 per cent of total expenses) was ORE.

FIGURE A12: Goal Area 3 - Expenses by Result Area, 2024

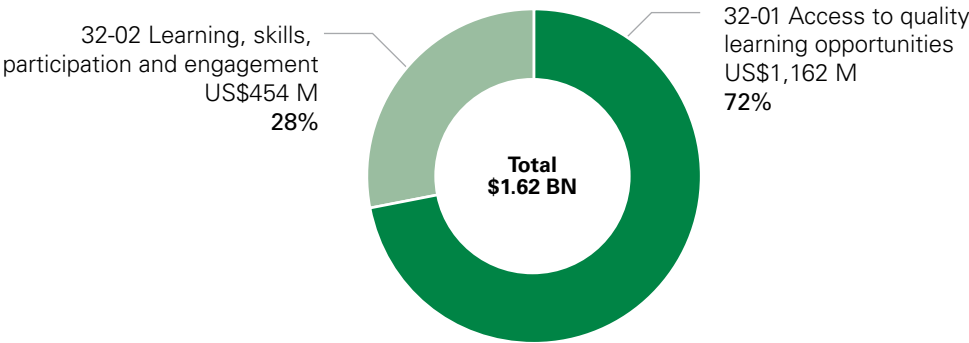
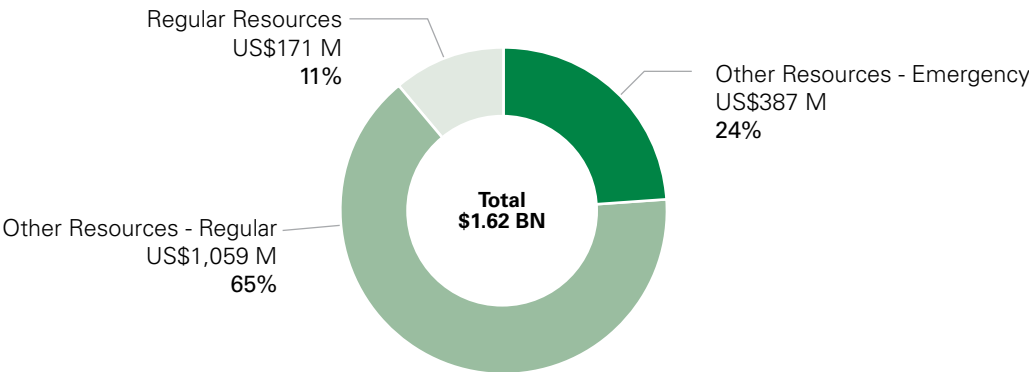


FIGURE A13: Goal Area 3 - Expenses by Fund Type, 2024



Countries affected by emergencies and protracted humanitarian crises continued to have some of the largest education expenses in 2024. The greatest amount of funding, \$193 million, was spent in Lebanon, and the Middle East and North Africa reported the most spending amongst regions.

FIGURE A14: Goal Area 3 - Expenses by fund type and top 20 countries, 2024

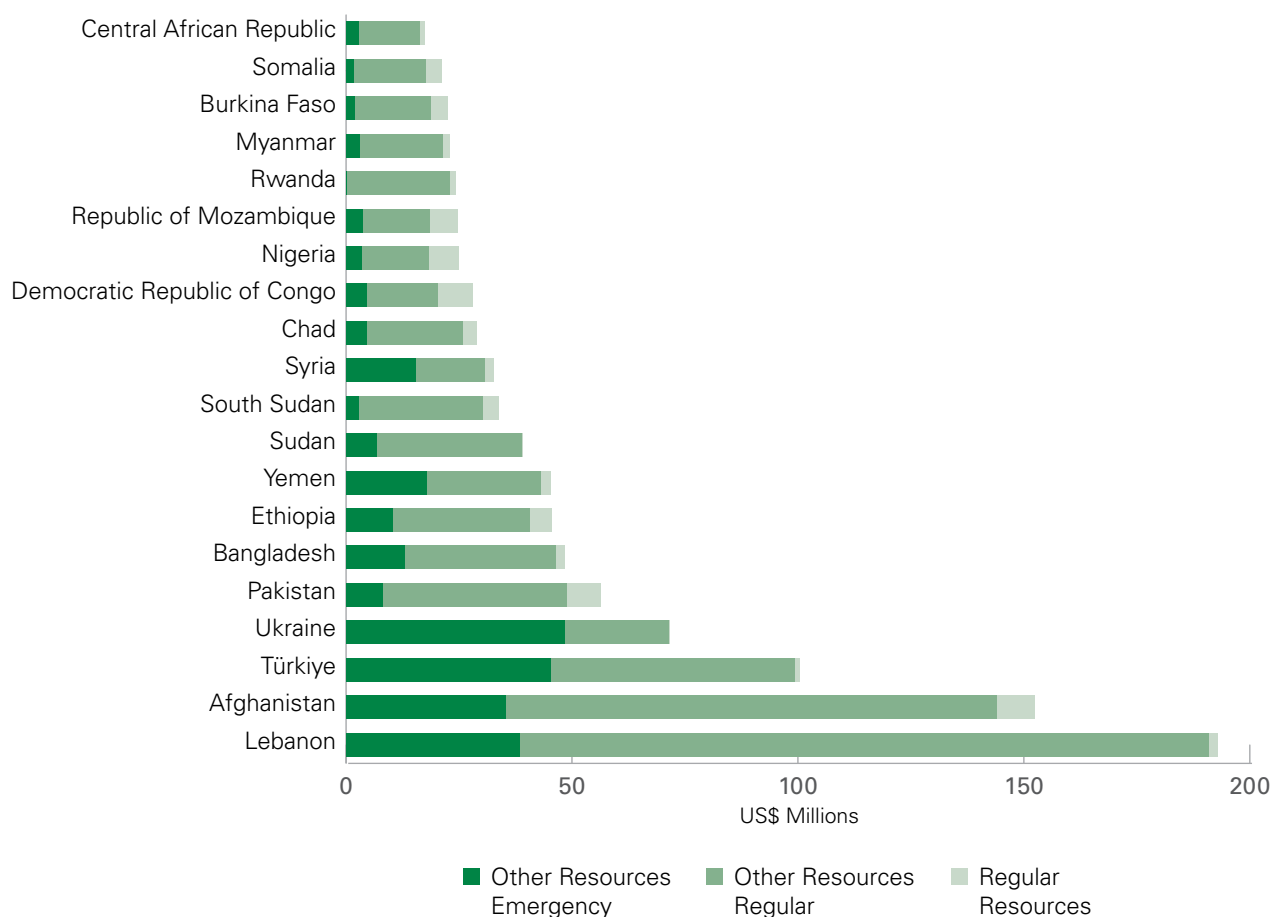
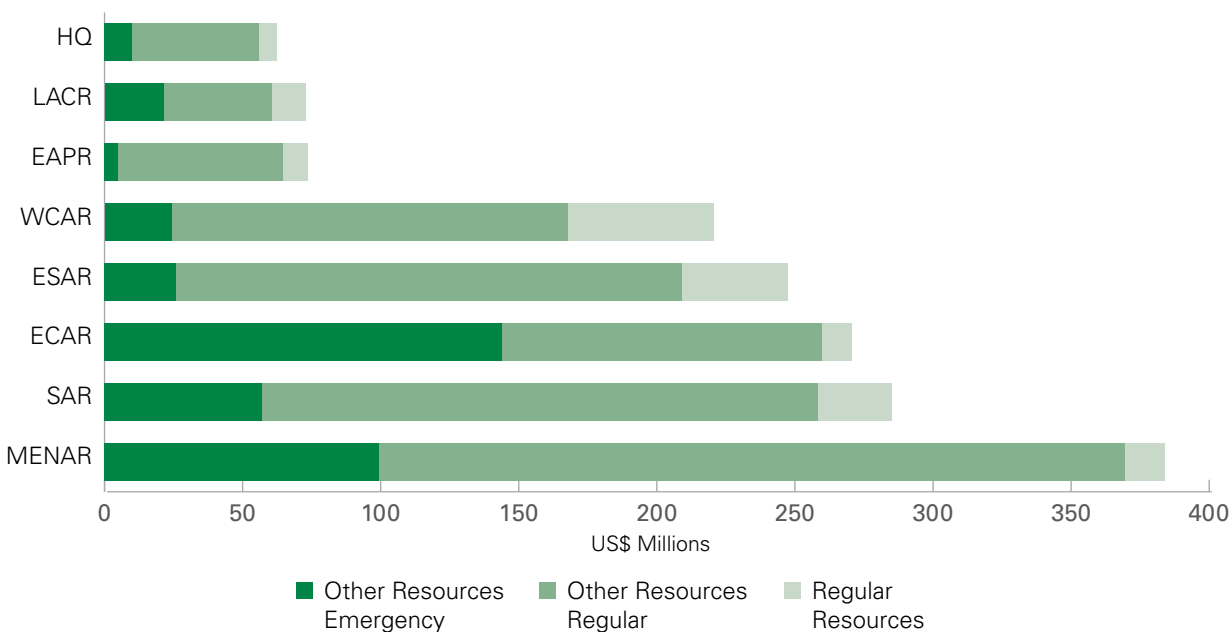


FIGURE A15: Goal Area 3 - Expenses by fund type and region, 2024



i All figures in this chapter have been rounded and may not add up to the totals.

ii Aside from OR contributions received for specific Goal Areas of the Strategic Plan 2022-2025, sectors and gender equality, other OR contributions were received for two or more Goal Areas and/or sectors. In total, \$2.77 billion was received as cross-sectoral OR contributions in 2024, of which 62% was for humanitarian response.



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